

GrowMailers Master Blueprint

Who We Sell To, How Big the Market Is, How Email Works, and How to Find Clients

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How to read this. Every section starts with a "bottom line" — one short paragraph that gives you the main point. If you only have ten minutes, read those. The rest of each section has the tables, step-by-step checklists and extra detail the team uses daily. All numbers come from named public sources as of September 2026 — the US Census Bureau, Store Leads, Klaviyo, and others. When we calculated something ourselves, we say so.

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1. What GrowMailers Does and Why It Works

Bottom line: Online brands today barely make any money from the first sale. All their profit comes from the second, third, and fourth times a customer buys. Email and text message (SMS) are the cheapest way to bring customers back. GrowMailers sells two services that help with this. **Ascent** is a \$5,000 one-time fix that makes sure a brand's emails actually reach the inbox. **Lhotse** is a \$3,000–\$5,500 per month service that runs the whole email program for the brand. The best clients use Shopify and Klaviyo and sell products people buy over and over. Lhotse is for brands making \$3M–\$20M a year. Ascent is for brands making \$1M–\$50M+.

1.1 The problem we solve

Three things are squeezing online brands right now.

Advertising costs more every year. Meta (Facebook and Instagram) raised its average ad price by 12% between mid-2025 and mid-2026. It has gone up 6–14% every three months since mid-2024. When ads cost more, getting each new customer costs more.

Shipping and products cost more. New import taxes (tariffs), higher shipping fees, and the end of tax-free entry for small packages into the US all cut into the profit margin. About 4 out of 5 brands said the 2025 tariff changes raised their costs.

Getting emails into the inbox is harder. Gmail, Yahoo, and Microsoft now block bulk emails if the brand's security settings are wrong. Every brand we target sends enough email to be affected by these new rules.

The result: brands only make real money when customers come back and buy again. Sending someone back to buy again via email costs almost nothing — a fraction of a cent per email. Getting that same person to buy for the first time through ads costs anywhere from \$30 to \$45 per purchase.

Most brands making \$3M–\$20M are still running the same basic email setup they built years ago. Their automatic email sequences are thin. They blast campaigns to their whole list instead of just active customers. They pay their email platform (Klaviyo) every month to store tens of thousands of subscribers who never open anything. And nobody has checked whether their emails are getting blocked since the security rules changed.

GrowMailers fixes that.

1.2 The two services

	Ascent	Lhotse
What it is	A one-time technical repair job	A monthly service that runs everything
Price	\$5,000	\$3,000–\$5,500 per month
What we do	Fix email security settings; get the brand off shared sending servers; clean the list; remove fake subscribers; repair inbox delivery; set up a warm-up plan	Write and schedule emails and texts; build automated sequences; clean the list; design emails; write copy; test what works; send reports
How long	2–3 weeks of fixing, then up to 10 weeks of careful ramp-up if a new sending address is needed	Ongoing, starting after 2–3 weeks of setup
Best for	Any brand making \$1M–\$50M+	Brands making \$3M–\$20M
When a brand calls us	Their emails keep bouncing, landing in spam, or their Klaviyo bill keeps going up	Email revenue is flat, they just lost their email person, a previous agency disappointed them
How we know it worked	Emails pass security checks; spam rate below 0.1%; fewer bounced emails; inbox rate improves	Email's share of website revenue goes up; more revenue per email sent; holdout tests confirm real lift (explained in Section 10)

Ascent is a repair project with a clear finish line. It is usually how we first get into a new account — we find a problem, fix it, and then the brand trusts us with bigger work.

We recommend pricing Lhotse in three tiers based on how much we do:

Package	Monthly price	Best for	What's included
Lhotse Core	\$3,000–\$3,500	\$3M–\$6M brands	All automated sequences built and running; 2–3 targeted campaigns per week; monthly report; list cleaning
Lhotse Growth	\$3,500–\$4,500	\$6M–\$12M brands	Everything in Core, plus a managed SMS program, regular tests, reorder reminder emails, and quarterly lift tests
Lhotse Scale	\$4,500–\$5,500	\$12M–\$20M brands	Everything in Growth, plus website conversion work, smarter list segmentation, multi-country calendars, and a weekly strategy call

This is a suggested structure — GrowMailers should confirm it matches how they actually package the work.

FREE AUDIT → ASCENT PROJECT → 30-DAY CHECK-IN → LHOTSE PROPOSAL
 (15 min) (\$5,000) (show them results) (\$3,000–5,500/mo)
 └ OR go straight to Lhotse if the technical setup is already fine ─

Start with Ascent when the free audit finds security or delivery problems — nobody should be scaling email on a broken setup. Start with Lhotse when everything works technically but the email program is thin. We also recommend giving the client a credit off their first Lhotse month if they sign up within 60 days of Ascent finishing. This turns Ascent into a paid trial.

1.3 How to justify the price

Compared to hiring someone. According to Glassdoor, a US Email Marketing Manager earns \$66,000–\$107,000 base salary. With taxes, benefits, and equipment, the real cost is about \$85,000–\$135,000 per year. That buys one person with one set of skills, who takes weeks to get up to speed, and who can leave at any time. Lhotse costs \$36,000–\$66,000 per year and brings a whole team — a strategist, a designer, a copywriter, and a delivery expert — from day one.

Compared to email revenue. Healthy brands earn 20–30% of their website revenue from email and texts:

Brand's annual revenue	Email revenue (at 20–30%)	Lhotse as a share of email revenue	Is it worth it?
\$1.5M	\$300k–\$450k	8–22%	Too expensive. Sell Ascent instead.
\$3M	\$600k–\$900k	4–11%	It works
\$5M	\$1.0M–\$1.5M	2.4–6.6%	Comfortable
\$10M	\$2.0M–\$3.0M	1.2–3.3%	Sweet spot
\$20M	\$4.0M–\$6.0M	0.6–1.7%	Very easy to justify

Compared to the cost of a problem. A \$5M brand earning \$1M a year from email makes about \$19,000 a week from it. If a security problem sends 25% of their emails to spam, they lose about \$4,800 a week — and much more during Black Friday week. Ascent pays for itself in one to two weeks of fixed delivery.

1.4 Why the second sale is where the money is

Here is what happens to the money on a typical clothing order, using real industry data:

FIRST SALE (customer found through ads)		SECOND SALE (customer comes back via email)	
Order value	\$103.37	Order value	\$103.37
- Product cost (33.5%)	-\$34.63	- Product cost (33.5%)	-\$34.63
- Shipping and fees	-\$23.88	- Shipping and fees	-\$23.88
- Ad cost	-\$39.24	- Email cost	≈ -\$0.10
PROFIT LEFT	≈ \$5.62	PROFIT LEFT	≈ \$44.76

The first sale buys the customer. The second sale earns the profit. Here, the second sale is worth about **8 times** more profit than the first. And every year that ad costs rise, that gap gets bigger.

We are not selling "better emails." We are selling more orders that cost the brand almost nothing to generate.

1.5 Our six promises to ourselves

- 1. Only sell to brands that own their customer list.** They must use Shopify (or Shopify Plus) and Klaviyo, own their products, and sell mainly through their own website.
- 2. Choose the right service based on facts.** Start with Ascent when we find technical problems. Start with Lhotse when the brand is \$3M–\$20M and their email program is underbuilt.
- 3. Focus on four product types.** Beauty and skincare, health supplements, food and drink, and pet supplies.
- 4. Respect the selling calendar.** Never pitch a monthly retainer in the weeks before Black Friday.
- 5. Prove results with real tests, not guesswork.** Use holdout tests (explained in Section 10), not just platform numbers.
- 6. Keep our own emails clean.** A company that fixes email delivery problems cannot afford to have its own emails blocked.

2. Types of Online Stores and Which Ones We Target

Bottom line: Whether a brand actually owns the contact information for its customers is what matters most — not how big the brand is. A \$30M Amazon seller is a worse prospect than a \$4M Shopify brand, because the Amazon seller cannot email most of its buyers. Dropshippers and print-on-demand stores are also excluded, even though they technically have an email list. They do not have the profit margin, product quality, or staying power to benefit from our work.

2.1 Types of online business and whether we can help

Business type	What it means	Can they email their customers?	Ascent fit	Lhotse fit
Direct-to-consumer brand (DTC)	Makes or owns its products; sells mainly through its own website	Yes, fully	Strong	Strong
Online-born brand (DNVB)	An online brand that controls everything from product design to delivery	Yes	Strong	Strong , if finances are healthy
Subscription brand	Most revenue is repeat deliveries, often set up through an app called ReCharge	Yes	Strong	Strong (great for reducing cancellations)
Multi-channel retailer	Has its own stores, website, and sells through big retailers too	Web buyers yes; in-store buyers partially	Strong (for large repair jobs)	Depends: measure only website revenue

Business type	What it means	Can they email their customers?	Ascent fit	Lhotse fit
Half Amazon, half own website	Sells a lot through Amazon and its own site	Only their own-site buyers	Maybe	Maybe: own site must be big enough alone
Wholesale brand	Sells mainly to retailers, not directly to shoppers	Small own-site list	Only if own site makes \$1M+	Skip
Marketplace-only seller	Only sells through Amazon, Etsy, or TikTok Shop	No. Amazon hides buyer emails.	Skip	Skip
Dropshipper	Has no stock; a supplier ships each order directly	Technically yes	Skip	Skip
Print-on-demand / creator merch	Products printed only when ordered (using apps like Printful)	Rarely their own list	Skip	Skip

The word "e-commerce" covers any online sale, from Amazon down to a one-person Shopify store. Only the rows marked Strong or Maybe are our market.

A survey by ShipBob in 2026 found 65% of brands say their own website is their main sales channel, 20% say Amazon, and 12% say wholesale or retail stores. Since 86% of brands sell through more than one channel, **always measure a potential client by their own website revenue only**. Amazon and wholesale sales never go through Klaviyo, so they do not count.

2.2 Why we skip dropshippers and print-on-demand

Email works best when customers run out of a product they love and trust the brand. Dropshipped generic products do not build that kind of loyalty. These businesses also:

- Do not have enough profit margin to pay for our services
- Often close within months, and our work depends on a domain the brand keeps for years
- Attract low-quality subscribers who hurt both results and the case studies we show future clients

They are easy to spot and skip. Printful and Printify are two of the top ten apps on US Shopify stores. An app called Fourthwall is used by 7% of US Shopify stores that also have Klaviyo.

2.3 Quick decision checklist — is this store worth pursuing?

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START → Is the brand's own website their main way to sell?
├─ NO → Does the website alone make $1M+ (for Ascent) or $3M+ (for Lhotse)?
│   └─ NO → SKIP (they sell mainly through Amazon or wholesalers)
│   └─ YES → KEEP GOING, but use only website revenue numbers
├─ YES → Do they make or own their products?
│   └─ NO → SKIP (dropshipper, print-on-demand, reseller)
│   └─ YES → Do they use Shopify or Shopify Plus?
│       └─ NO → HOLD (check back later)
│       └─ YES → Do they use Klaviyo for emails?
│           └─ Omnisend → HOLD (never make them switch)
│           └─ Mailchimp → NURTURE (introduce our work)
│           └─ YES → Is it beauty, supplements, food, or pets?
│               └─ YES → QUALIFIED. Score it (Section 4).
│               └─ NO → SECONDARY. Only if repeat buying is visible.

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2.4 Tricky cases

- **A \$25M brand with 60% of sales on Amazon.** Their website makes \$10M — that qualifies for Lhotse. Use only the website number, and expect email to cover a smaller share of revenue since Amazon buyers never joined the email list.
- **A brand with physical stores.** Great Ascent candidate — more sending tools (like a store POS system) mean more security gaps to fix. For Lhotse, check if in-store buyers are added to Klaviyo at checkout.
- **A company that owns several brands.** Each brand has its own email domain and list, so each one is a separate Ascent project. Pitch the whole group, but price each brand separately.
- **A brand where most revenue is subscriptions.** Subscriptions do not count as "email revenue" in Klaviyo reporting, so email looks weaker than it really is. Judge by cancelled subscription prevention and cross-selling instead.
- **A Shopify Plus store with a custom build.** Website scanning tools might not detect their apps. Confirm by signing up for their email list and reading the technical headers in the email you receive (Section 18 explains how).

3. Why Ad Costs Are Killing Profit (and How Email Fixes It)

Bottom line: Online shopping keeps growing, but the cost of getting each new customer is growing faster than the profit that customer brings on their first order. At the current rate of ad price increases, the average clothing brand's first sale will lose money within two years. Email keeps customers coming back at almost no cost — and that is what GrowMailers sells.

3.1 How big is online shopping?

The US Census Bureau reported \$340.2 billion in US online shopping in just the second quarter of 2026 — that is 17.1% of all retail and 12.2% more than the same quarter the year before. The full year 2025 was about \$1.23 trillion.

Brands that sell direct to consumers (cutting out retailers and selling directly to shoppers) make up about 19% of US online shopping, roughly \$234 billion. That share is expected to stay about the same through 2028.

But there is a catch: some of that growth comes from higher prices due to tariffs and inflation, not more units sold. Brands are making more dollars, but not necessarily making more profit.

3.2 Why ads keep getting more expensive

Meta (Facebook/Instagram) reported a 12% rise in its average ad price in mid-2026, while the number of times an ad was shown went up 14%. If conversion rates stay the same, that means brands spend about 12% more to get each purchase. Google advertising works the same way — it is an auction, and prices keep going up.

Here is what happens to a clothing brand's profit per first order if ad costs keep rising at 12% a year:

Year	Ad cost per purchase	Profit left from first order
Today	\$39.24	\$5.62
+1 year	\$43.95	\$0.91
+2 years	\$49.22	-\$4.36 (a loss)
+3 years	\$55.13	-\$10.27 (a bigger loss)

Our estimate, assuming prices and conversion rates stay the same.

This does not cause an immediate crisis. The first order just earns a little less money each month, until quietly it starts losing money. Brands that already earn profit from repeat customers can handle this. Brands that do not will find their growth plan stops working.

3.3 Import taxes (tariffs) and higher costs

Import rules changed several times in 2026. The US paused duty-free entry (where small packages below \$800 came in without taxes) and is ending it permanently on 1 July 2027. Brands that make products overseas now pay higher import taxes. Brands in Canada, the UK, and Australia that ship to US customers now face duties they did not pay before.

Several DTC businesses closed in 2025 because of this combination: tariffs, inflation, higher ad costs, and less investment money available.

3.4 The cost of getting a new customer vs. keeping one

There are two ways to measure ad spend per customer:

- **Cost per purchase:** ad spend divided by all purchases, new and returning together. This is what Triple Whale (an analytics tool) reports.
- **Cost per new customer:** ad spend divided by *new* customers only. This is always higher than cost per purchase.

How many sales it takes to recover the cost of getting a new customer:

Beauty example: Cost per new customer $\approx$ \$50 (1.5 $\times$ the \$33.44 cost per purchase)
 Profit per sale $\approx$ \$38.93 (after product and shipping, before ads)
 → Takes about 1.3 sales to break even

In beauty, supplements, and clothing, a brand needs about 1.3–1.6 sales to recover the cost of getting that customer. In food and pet, it takes 2.2–2.5 sales. **In every product type we target, the brand needs customers to come back.**

3.5 Why getting customers back is so profitable

Getting customers back (called "retention") earns more money through three levers:

1. **Repeat rate** — what percentage of buyers come back at all
2. **Frequency** — how often they buy
3. **Profit per repeat order** — bundles, upsells, and not giving away unnecessary discounts

Example: A \$8M beauty brand gets 50,000 new customers a year. If their 12-month repeat rate goes from 25% to 30%, that is 2,500 more returning customers. At 1.4 orders each and about \$39 profit per order, that is roughly **\$136,000 of extra profit per year** — from one improvement. That is 2–4 times the annual cost of Lhotse.

3.6 How to talk about this with clients

- **Talk about profit, not email open rates.** "Orders you don't pay Facebook for" is what founders and finance people care about.
- **Compare Lhotse to buying the same orders through ads.** At a \$40 average ad cost per purchase, 150 extra repeat orders a month would cost \$6,000 in ad spend. Lhotse is the same price.

- **Do not use made-up statistics.** The popular claim that "customer acquisition costs rose 60% in five years" comes from a 2022 vendor blog post with no real data behind it. Smart buyers know this.

4. How to Read a Store's Tech Setup to Know If It's a Good Fit

Bottom line: The apps a brand uses on their website tell us their size, budget, and likely problems — before we ever talk to them. Shopify plus Klaviyo is the minimum requirement. When a brand also uses paid growth tools like Attentive or Northbeam, that signals a larger brand with a real retention budget. We use these signals to give each prospect two scores: a **Lhotse Fit Score** (how good a Lhotse client they would be) and an **Ascent Urgency Score** (how badly their email delivery needs fixing).

4.1 What tools DTC brands use

STOREFRONT	Shopify · Shopify Plus (\$2,300–2,500/month)
EMAIL & SMS	Klaviyo · Postscript · Attentive · Omnisend
SUBSCRIPTIONS	ReCharge (handles repeat delivery orders)
ANALYTICS	Triple Whale · Northbeam (ad tracking tools)
CUSTOMER SERVICE	Gorgias (support chat/tickets) · Okendo/Yotpo (reviews)
FULFILLMENT	3PL warehouse partner (84% of brands use one)

Every tool that sends emails on the brand's behalf (support, reviews, subscriptions) is another one we need to check in an Ascent audit.

4.2 What each tool tells us

Tool	How many US Shopify stores use it	What it signals	What we say in our pitch
Shopify Plus	2.5%	Strong signal of a bigger brand (fees alone cost \$27,600+/yr, so this is almost always a \$1M+ brand)	Good fit for both services
Klaviyo	14.5%	Required — this is the gate	Both
Attentive	0.58%	Large brand, enterprise-level, big SMS budget	Ascent; Lhotse Scale
Northbeam	0.11%	Large ad budget, team that cares about measurement	Lead with real lift results
Postscript	1.7%	Running SMS, has a retention budget	Lhotse Growth
ReCharge	2.1%	Repeat-purchase model is already running	Focus on reducing cancellations, cross-selling
Triple Whale	1.3%	Tracks all marketing spend carefully	Frame results as "lower blended marketing cost"
Gorgias	1.0%	Has a customer service team sending from the brand domain	Check email security settings on support emails
Mailchimp	5.8%	Rarely a serious email program	Nurture gently
Omnisend alone	2.2%	Often a deliberate choice	Hold — never push them to switch platforms

Tool	How many US Shopify stores use it	What it signals	What we say in our pitch
Printful / Printify / Fourthwall	Top-10 apps	Print-on-demand — skip	Skip

Counts from Store Leads data, 1,179,951 live US Shopify stores, September 2026.

Three important platform facts:

- Klaviyo is growing fast.** Revenue grew 26% in mid-2026. Brands paying Klaviyo more than \$50,000/year grew 36%. Bigger brands are investing heavily in email.
- Shopify rewrites the email sender** when a brand has no security record (DMARC) set up. The email shows up to customers as being from "shopifyemail.com" instead of the brand's domain — this is a clear sign the brand needs Ascent.
- Owners love Klaviyo's power but hate the bill.** GrowMailers sells the expertise to make Klaviyo worth paying for. We never push them to switch.

4.3 How to score a prospect

Lhotse Fit Score (out of 100) — "How good a Lhotse client would this be?"

Score = Platform (0–20) + Size (0–30) + Tools they use (0–20) +
Product type (0–15) + Email program gaps (0–15) – Penalties

GATE: If they don't use Klaviyo → Score = 0 (hold or nurture)

What we measure	Criteria	Points
Platform	Shopify Plus / regular Shopify above \$250k/month in sales / below that	20 / 12 / 0
Size (estimated monthly sales)	\$420k–\$1.0M/month (\$5M–\$12M/year)	30
	\$1.0M–\$1.67M/month (\$12M–\$20M/year) OR \$250k–\$420k (\$3M–\$5M/year)	25 / 20
	Above \$1.67M OR below \$250k/month	10 / 5
Tools used (max 20)	Postscript or Attentive +6; ReCharge +6; Triple Whale or Northbeam +5; Gorgias +3; reviews or loyalty app +3	up to 20
Product type	Beauty, supplements, food, or pets / clothing with repeat buying / other	15 / 8 / 3
Email gaps (max 15, from audit)	Only one welcome email or none +5; blasting full list more than 4x/week +4; no browse-abandonment email +3; no post-purchase or reorder reminder +3	up to 15
Deductions	Registered business agent address –20; hired email agency in last 6 months –10; dropshipper or print-on-demand → skip	

Ascent Urgency Score (out of 100) — "How badly does their email delivery need fixing?"

What we measure	Criteria	Points
Security setting gaps (max 40)	No DMARC record 20; two or broken DMARC records 20; emails show "via klaviyomail.com" above 5,000 subscribers 20; Shopify is rewriting their email sender 15; SPF record is broken 10	up to 40

What we measure	Criteria	Points
How exposed they are (max 30)	List above 50,000 10; using SMS heavily with frequent sends 10; in UK/Canada/Australia where Microsoft is big 5; Black Friday within 12 weeks 5	up to 30
Visible signs of problems (max 30)	Test emails land in spam at 2+ email providers 15; order confirmation emails land in spam 10; no one-click unsubscribe button 10; welcome email arrives more than 1 hour late 5	up to 30

Priority guide

ASCENT URGENCY SCORE			
		Low (under 40)	High (40+)
LHOTSE FIT SCORE	High (60+)	LHOTSE FIRST Lead with program gaps and upside	ASCENT FIRST, THEN LHOTSE Fix delivery, then pitch the retainer
	Low (60)	NURTURE / SKIP Check back in 3 months	ASCENT ONLY For \$1-3M or \$20M+ brands

4.4 Always verify before reaching out

Tech databases can be wrong and miss some setups. Before reaching out to any prospect, confirm by hand:

- Klaviyo is live (sign up for their list and check the email you receive)
- Emails actually arrive after signup
- The growth tools are visible on the site (a ReCharge membership portal, a Gorgias chat widget)

A wrong signal leads to a wrong pitch.

Australia has the highest rate of Klaviyo use among the six countries we target — 23.6% of their Shopify stores use Klaviyo, compared to 14.5% in the US. Australian and UK brands tend to be more experienced, so lead with delivery depth and measurement rather than basics.

5. Who Our Perfect Clients Are

Bottom line: Our ideal client is a Shopify or Shopify Plus brand using Klaviyo that owns its products and sells mainly through its own website, in beauty, supplements, food, or pets. **Lhotse** targets brands making \$3M–\$20M per year. That is the size where email earns \$600k–\$6M per year, and a \$36k–\$66k annual retainer makes more sense than hiring a \$70k–\$100k+ employee. **Ascent** targets brands making \$1M–\$50M+, including large brands with in-house teams who need a specialist repair job.

5.1 The entry requirements (must have ALL of these)

Requirement	What it means	How we check
Uses Shopify or Shopify Plus	Their online store runs on Shopify	Store Leads database; look at the website source code

Requirement	What it means	How we check
Uses Klaviyo for emails	Their email platform is Klaviyo	Sign up for their email list; check the email headers
Owns their email list	Their own website is their main sales channel	Look at the site; Amazon is not the primary "buy" button
Owns their products	Makes or sells branded products (not drop-shipped generics)	No dropshipping apps on their store; branded product pages
Minimum revenue	\$1M+/year for Ascent, or the minimum for their product type for Lhotse (see table below)	Store Leads estimated monthly sales
Location	US, UK, Canada, Australia, Ireland, or New Zealand — confirmed as their real base	Check their address, phone, founder's LinkedIn, and shipping origin
Legal contact	We have a legal way to reach a decision-maker	Record where we found the contact

5.2 Ascent client tiers (all technical repair jobs)

	A1: Small brand	A2: Growing brand	A3: Large brand
Annual revenue	\$1M–\$3M	\$3M–\$20M	\$20M–\$50M+
Estimated monthly sales	\$83k–\$250k	\$250k–\$1.67M	\$1.67M–\$4.2M+
Typical team size	3–10 people	8–40 people	40–80+ people
Active Klaviyo subscribers	10k–40k	40k–250k	250k–1M+
Emails sent per month	50k–250k	250k–1.5M	1.5M–8M+
Who signs the contract	Founder	Founder (under \$5M); Head of Marketing above	CMO or VP; finance reviews
Common reason for calling	Shopify is rewriting their sender; shared Klaviyo domain; fake subscribers; rising bill	Emails landing in Microsoft spam; sudden bounce spike; worried about Black Friday	Moving to a new sending domain; enforcing security settings; recovering from an incident
How we pitch it	"Fix the foundation once, for under 0.5% of revenue"	"Protect the channel that earns you \$1M+ a year"	"A specialist repair your team can hand off — no disruption to sending"

5.3 Lhotse client tiers (monthly retainer)

	L1: Entry	L2: Core (sweet spot)	L3: Scale
Annual revenue	\$3M–\$5M	\$5M–\$12M	\$12M–\$20M
Email revenue (at 20–30%)	\$600k–\$1.5M	\$1.0M–\$3.6M	\$2.4M–\$6.0M
Suggested price	Core (\$3,000–\$3,500)	Growth (\$3,500–\$4,500)	Scale (\$4,500–\$5,500)
Retainer as share of email revenue	2.4–7%	1.2–5.4%	0.9–2.8%
Who makes the decision	Founder	Head of Marketing or Head of Growth	CMO or VP of Marketing; a retention person influences the decision
What they are currently doing instead	A freelancer, or the founder doing it themselves	About to hire their first email specialist	Has an in-house team but also uses an agency
How we pitch it	"A full retention team for less than one hire"	"Stop hiring for skills you need part-time"	"Strategy, delivery, and testing your team doesn't have time for"

Below \$3M: Lhotse would take 12–22% of a \$1.5M brand's email revenue. That's too much. Sell Ascent and revisit later.

Above \$20M: These brands usually have in-house retention teams. Ascent is the right entry point.

Revenue floors by product type (from the profit data in Section 8):

Product type	Minimum revenue for Lhotse	Reason
Beauty and skincare	\$3M	About \$39 profit per repeat order
Health supplements	\$3M	High margins and a 30-day reorder cycle
Pet supplies	\$4M	Only about \$22 profit per repeat order
Food and drink	\$5M	Only about \$17 profit per repeat order

A food or pet brand with unusually large orders (above about \$90 average) or a strong subscription base can qualify at \$3M.

5.4 Why these four product types

US Klaviyo users are more concentrated in these categories than the average Shopify store:

- Beauty and fitness: 12.8% of Klaviyo stores vs 10.9% of all Shopify stores
- Food and drink: 8.8% vs 7.1%
- Health: 7.3% vs 4.4%

The key is that customers **run out of the product and buy again** — this is what makes email so valuable.

Product type	Typical time between reorders	Best automated email sequences	Watch out for
Beauty and skincare	30–75 days	Quiz-based welcome, reorder reminder, reviews, VIP program	Returns because of shade match; heavy discounting culture
Health supplements	30 days	Reorder reminder, subscription cancellation save, education series	Health claim regulations (FTC in US, ASA in UK, TGA in Australia)
Food and drink	14–45 days	Back-in-stock, reorder, seasonal	Low profit margins; products expire; expensive to ship
Pet supplies	30–45 days	Reorder, pet birthday, win-back	Competing with Chewy and Amazon Subscribe & Save

Reorder timing is a planning estimate. Always replace with the brand's own average days between orders.

Clothing is the largest category on Shopify (29.1% of US stores) and is a secondary target. It qualifies when repeat buying is visible — basics, uniforms, or restockable essentials.

5.5 Who to skip

Why we skip them	How to spot them	What to do
Marketplace-only or mainly Amazon	No real checkout on their own site; "Buy on Amazon" is the main button	Skip
Dropshipper	DSers, Zendrop, AutoDS, or CJdropshipping apps; 2–4 week shipping; generic products	Skip
Print-on-demand or creator merch	Printful, Printify, Fourthwall, or Spring	Skip
Does not own the customer relationship	Resellers, affiliates, or white-label stores	Skip

Why we skip them	How to spot them	What to do
No email tool, or basic Mailchimp with no automation	No welcome email after signup	Nurture
Registered-agent address	Address matches a known business agent, founder actually based abroad	Verify, then re-tag or skip
Too small	Estimated sales under \$83k/month, or under the product-type floor	Nurture; rescore in 3 months
\$50M+ with their own in-house team	CRM job postings; large marketing team	Ascent repair only
Canada or UK brand with only a personal Gmail address	Contact data shows a Gmail	Do not cold email
Hired an email agency in the last 6 months	Agency credited in emails or posts	Nurture; revisit in 9–12 months

5.6 What our perfect Lhotse client looks like

This is an example, not a real brand. A \$7M health supplement brand based in Austin, Texas, on Shopify Plus. 85% of revenue comes from their own website. They have 18 staff and a three-person marketing team led by a Head of Growth. They use Klaviyo, Postscript, ReCharge, Triple Whale, and Gorgias.

Their email list has 95,000 people in it, but only about 35,000 have clicked or bought something in the last six months. Their welcome email sequence is only two emails long. They have no reorder reminder email, even though 60% of their revenue comes from 30-day products. Email drives 14% of their website revenue.

This brand scores about 85 on the Lhotse Fit Score and 35 on the Ascent Urgency Score — which means we lead with Lhotse. In the first three months, we would: build reorder and post-purchase email sequences; move campaigns to engaged-only segments; remove about 40,000 inactive people from the list (cutting their Klaviyo bill); and set up a holdout test so the Head of Growth can show the founder real, proven numbers — not just platform estimates.

6. How Many Potential Clients Exist and Where They Are

Bottom line: The usable pool of potential clients — anchored on Shopify Plus brands — is roughly **4,500 brands across six countries**, about two-thirds of them in the US. At our midpoint monthly fee, that pool is worth about \$230M per year in possible revenue. GrowMails only needs to win well under 1% of it. The limit is not the size of the market — it's our own delivery capacity. Also: some cities show thousands of Shopify stores because overseas founders register their businesses there — those are not real local brands and must be filtered out.

6.1 How many Shopify stores are there?

Country	All Shopify stores	Shopify Plus stores	Stores using Klaviyo	Online shopping share of all retail
United States	1,179,951	28,965	203,080	About 16.4%
United Kingdom	231,312	6,311	43,546	27.5%
Canada	147,721	3,812	22,584	7.5%
Australia	138,276	3,725	35,621	24%
New Zealand	26,522	581	5,322	Not available
Ireland	12,873	502	2,786	5.7%
Total	1,736,655	43,896	312,939	

Store Leads data, 18 September 2026.

6.2 Narrowing down to real prospects

Shopify Plus stores across six countries	43,896
÷ 1.5 (some owners have multiple domains)	
Distinct Shopify Plus businesses	≈ 29,263
× 60% using Klaviyo (planning estimate)	
Plus brands that use Klaviyo	≈ 17,558
× 30% in beauty, supplements, food, or pets	
Brands in our target product types	≈ 5,268
× 85% after removing dropshippers, etc.	
REAL PROSPECT POOL	≈ 4,478 brands

Country	Shopify Plus brands	Using Klaviyo	In target product types	Real prospect pool	Share
United States	19,310	11,586	3,476	2,955	66%
United Kingdom	4,207	2,524	757	643	14%
Canada	2,541	1,525	458	389	9%
Australia	2,483	1,490	447	380	8%
New Zealand	387	232	70	60	1%
Ireland	335	201	60	51	1%
Total	29,263	17,558	5,268	4,478	100%

These are estimates. Australia's real number is probably higher.

Important: This only counts Shopify Plus stores. Many smaller brands (\$1M–\$5M) use regular Shopify and are not counted here. The real pool is larger.

Validation step: Use GrowMailers' paid Store Leads account to export real counts by country, filtered to Klaviyo and our categories, in specific revenue ranges. Replace these estimates with real data.

Level	What it includes	Number of brands	Annual value
Total market	All Plus brands on Klaviyo, any product type	≈ 17,558	≈ \$895M
Reachable market	Our four product types	≈ 4,478	≈ \$228M retainer value + ≈ \$22M one-time Ascent
Target in 12–24 months	12–20 Lhotse clients and 30–50 Ascent projects per year	42–70	≈ \$760k–\$1.27M/year (0.3–0.5% of reachable market)

Delivery capacity limits us, not demand.

6.3 Each country's role

Country	Role	Key cities	Email risk	Special notes
United States	Primary, year-round (~2,955 brands)	California, New York, Florida, Texas, New Jersey, Utah	Gmail is dominant (54.4%)	Most lenient B2B email laws
United Kingdom	Secondary; best in Q1 (~643)	London (52,471 stores)	Microsoft is 32.3% of inboxes	Always test Microsoft delivery in every audit
Australia	Secondary; best Jan–Mar and Jul–Aug (~380)	New South Wales, Victoria	Microsoft is 30.2% of inboxes	Most experienced Klaviyo market; lead with depth

Country	Role	Key cities	Email risk	Special notes
Canada	Selective (~389)	Ontario (44.7%), Quebec (19.5%)	Microsoft is 27.9%	Strictest email marketing laws (CASL); Quebec needs French
Ireland	Add-on to UK (~51)	Dublin	Microsoft-heavy (estimated)	Company email addresses only — not personal Gmail
New Zealand	Add-on to Australia (~60)	Auckland (11,232 stores)	No public data	13% of stores are food brands

6.4 Best US states to target

State	Shopify stores with 10–49 staff	Klaviyo usage	Notes
California	3,407	16.6%	Largest cluster; beauty and wellness
New York	1,730	Not tracked	Fashion and beauty density
Florida	1,134	14.8%	Many stores, but few are big enough. Filter tightly.
Texas	983	13.6%	Same as Florida
New Jersey	469	Not tracked	Consumer goods and beauty
Utah	411	18.8%	Highest Klaviyo rate measured; supplements cluster
Illinois	398	13.5%	Food and consumer goods
Colorado	380	15.3%	Outdoor, pet, natural products

In Florida, Texas, and Georgia, only 1–1.5% of stores have 10+ staff, versus 3–3.8% in California and New York. Use stricter revenue filters in those states.

6.5 Watch out for fake US addresses

The town of Sheridan, Wyoming (population under 20,000) has 20,043 Shopify stores — the third highest of any US city. This is not a real DTC boom. It happens because founders outside the US set up an American business using a registered agent, and that agent's address becomes the store's listed address. The same thing happens in Cheyenne, Wyoming; Delaware; New Mexico; and at shared office addresses in London.

How to filter these out:

1. Flag any address that matches a known registered-agent location
2. Check for a local phone number, a real returns address, and confirmed shipping origin
3. Find where the founder actually works, using LinkedIn or the About page
4. If they are actually based outside our six countries, skip them. If they are inside, update their country tag and apply that country's laws.
5. Log the check in your CRM

6.6 Time zone guide (working from Nepal)

The GrowMails team works in Nepal Standard Time (NPT, 5 hours and 45 minutes ahead of London/UTC):

Market	Their business hours in Nepal time	Best approach
UK and Ireland	1:45 PM – 9:45 PM Nepal time	Best overlap for calls; schedule for their afternoon
Australia (Sydney)	4:45 AM – 12:45 PM Nepal time	Call Australian afternoons during Nepal mornings

Market	Their business hours in Nepal time	Best approach
New Zealand (Auckland)	2:45 AM – 10:45 AM Nepal time	Nepal mornings; schedule emails
US and Canada Eastern	6:45 PM – 2:45 AM Nepal time	Evening call shift; schedule emails
US and Canada Pacific	9:45 PM – 5:45 AM Nepal time	Late calls; schedule emails

Schedule every outreach email to arrive at 8–10 AM in the recipient's time zone.

7. Who Makes the Buying Decision and What They Care About

Bottom line: For brands under \$5M, the founder signs everything. From \$5M to \$20M, a marketing leader signs and a retention specialist influences them. Above \$20M, finance reviews the contract. Founders care about cash and profit. Growth leaders care about lowering their blended marketing cost. Retention staff care about getting relief from heavy workload and risk. Lhotse starts competing directly with a new hire when the brand would normally be considering their first email specialist — usually between \$3M and \$8M in revenue.

7.1 How teams change as brands grow

Revenue	Marketing team	How much they spend on outside agencies	Who runs email	Who signs contracts
\$1M–\$3M	2–3 people	About 5% of revenue	Founder or freelancer	Founder
\$3M–\$8M	4–6, including an email person	About 7%	First email hire	Founder
\$8M–\$20M	7–12	About 7%	Retention specialist	VP Marketing, CMO, or Head of Growth
\$20M–\$50M	15–25, led by a VP or CMO	About 5%	Head of Retention + team	CMO or VP; finance reviews

Between about \$3M and \$15M, brands shift from needing "a Klaviyo specialist" to needing "a retention strategist." Many have someone who can build an email sequence but no one who can design a full retention strategy — and Lhotse fills exactly that gap.

Also: as brands get bigger, they spend a smaller share of revenue on marketing. Brands under \$5M spend 30–45% of revenue on marketing. Ten public consumer brands spend a median of 13.3%. Smaller brands feel every dollar, so for small clients (L1), we sell Lhotse as a money-saver, not just a growth driver.

\$3M BRAND Founder/CEO Operations Marketing (generalist) Customer service Email: founder/freelancer ← LHOTSE L1	\$10M BRAND Founder/CEO Head of Growth Paid media Email / retention ← LHOTSE Creative Finance Customer service (LHOTSE L2 competes with the email/retention hire)	\$30M BRAND CEO CMO Head of Retention Email manager SMS manager CRM analyst Paid media VP ← ASCENT A3
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7.2 The four types of decision-makers

	Founder / CEO	Head of Marketing / Head of Growth	CMO	Retention Specialist
Responsible for	Cash, profit, strategy	Growing revenue per marketing dollar	Brand, growth, team	Email sequences, campaigns, list health, delivery
What they measure	Cash, contribution margin, marketing efficiency	Marketing efficiency, new customer revenue, ad cost per customer	Growth, lifetime value vs. acquisition cost, team productivity	Flow revenue, email share, spam and bounce rates
Biggest fear	Paying an agency that overpromises	Missing revenue targets as ad costs rise	A public failure during Black Friday or peak season	Being blamed for a deliverability incident; burning out
What they need to hear	"Here's the cost, the payback, and how you'll know if it's working."	"Owned-channel revenue lowers your blended marketing cost."	"Specialist depth, measured by real lift tests, no risk to peak season."	"We take the heavy lifting and fix what you haven't had time for."
Evidence they trust	A model built with their own numbers	Holdout-tested lift results	Case studies at their revenue level	Technical audit findings and a clear process
Best starting offer	Ascent A1 or Lhotse Core	Lhotse Growth	Ascent A3, then Lhotse Scale	Ascent, positioned as their ally — not their replacement
What kills the deal	Vague promises; long lock-in contracts	Vanity metrics like "open rates"	A junior team; no risk management plan	Anything that makes them feel threatened

7.3 How to handle common objections

Objection	What they really mean	Our response	Evidence we offer
"We already have an agency."	Inertia, or quiet dissatisfaction	"No need to switch. Ascent is a technical repair job most agencies don't do. Here's what we found in your email headers."	The external audit results
"We'll just hire someone."	They think a hire is cheaper	"A good hire costs \$85k–\$135k fully loaded and has one skill set. Lhotse is \$36k–\$66k and brings a whole team."	Section 1.3 comparison
"Our open rates are fine."	Open rates are inflated by Apple auto-opens	"Apple auto-opens most emails without anyone actually reading them. Let's look at clicks and actual orders placed."	Section 10 benchmarks
"Klaviyo says delivery is fine."	Averages hide problems at specific providers	"About a third of UK, Canadian, and Australian inboxes are Microsoft. Let's check by provider specifically."	Provider-level check
"Not right now, it's Black Friday prep."	A real freeze — do not push	"Completely understood — no retainer now. Here are two quick safe fixes, and let's book a January conversation."	Section 16 safe-fix list
"Too expensive."	ROI is not clear yet, or cash is tight	"At your margins, Lhotse needs about 80–140 extra repeat orders a month. You already do 6,000."	Section 8 breakeven math
"An agency already disappointed us."	Past over-promising	"What did they measure? We report lift tested against a control group, not platform credits."	Sample holdout test report

Objection	What they really mean	Our response	Evidence we offer
"Isn't not having DMARC enforcement a failure?"	A scare tactic from past vendors	"No — a monitoring-only DMARC record meets every major email provider's rules. Moving to enforcement is best practice, done carefully, not urgently."	Section 13

8. How Much Money Each Type of Product Makes

Bottom line: For every product type we target, the first sale through ads barely breaks even — or actually loses money. Profit starts with the second order. Beauty and supplements have the best margins, so Lhotse pays for itself fastest there. Food and pet earn less per sale, so we need a higher revenue minimum for those. Also: when brands automatically put a discount in every repeat-order email "out of habit," they can wipe out a third of their profit per sale. Managing discounts is part of what Lhotse does.

8.1 What real company financials look like

Company	Revenue	Gross profit rate	Marketing spend	Net profit
FIGS (US clothing, 2025)	\$631M	66.5%	14.8% of revenue	5.4% net
Hims & Hers (US health, 2025)	\$2.3B	74%	39% of revenue	5.5% net
Temple & Webster (AU home goods, 2026)	A\$665M	30.2%	15.2% of revenue	3.3% operating profit

Even at large scale with strong gross margins, DTC brands make only about 5% net profit. The ones that survive are built on repeat customers. At Temple & Webster, 62% of orders in their latest year came from repeat customers.

8.2 Profit per order by product type

Product type	Average order size	Gross margin	Shipping and payment fees	Average ad cost per purchase	Profit on first order	Profit on repeat order
Clothing	\$103.37	60%	15%	\$39.24	\$7.27	\$46.51
Beauty	\$68.29	72%	15%	\$33.44	\$5.49	\$38.93
Supplements	\$71.26	72%	14%	\$44.81	-\$3.48 (a loss)	\$41.33
Food and drink	\$69.87	45%	20%	\$28.96	-\$11.49 (a loss)	\$17.47
Pet	\$69.95	50%	18%	\$32.68	-\$10.29 (a loss)	\$22.39

Order sizes and ad costs are from Triple Whale's real customer data, US DTC brands, mid-2026. Margins and fee rates are our planning estimates — replace with each brand's real numbers during a discovery call.

8.3 How profit builds over time

PROFIT ACCUMULATED PER CUSTOMER (each bar block ≈ \$5; negative means a loss)



Product type	Expected orders in 12 months	Total profit at 12 months	Expected orders in 24 months	Total profit at 24 months
Clothing	1.4	\$25.87	1.7	\$39.83
Beauty	1.6	\$28.85	2.1	\$48.31
Supplements	2.2	\$46.12	3.0	\$79.18
Food and drink	2.0	\$5.98	2.8	\$19.96
Pet	2.3	\$18.82	3.3	\$41.21

Expected order counts are planning estimates. Use each brand's real data when available.

Supplements has the best economics. Even though the first order loses money, the 30-day reorder cycle quickly turns it positive. Food makes very little per sale at every stage, which is why it needs frequency and bigger basket sizes to work.

8.4 How many extra repeat orders do our services need to generate?

Product type	Profit per repeat order	To pay for Lhotse at \$3,000/mo	To pay for Lhotse at \$5,500/mo	To pay for Ascent (\$5,000 once)
Clothing	\$46.51	65 extra orders/month	119 extra orders/month	108 extra orders total
Beauty	\$38.93	78	142	129
Supplements	\$41.33	73	134	121
Food and drink	\$17.47	172	315	287
Pet	\$22.39	134	246	224

In perspective: A \$5M beauty brand does about 6,100 orders per month. Lhotse needs 78–142 of those to be extra orders it generated — that is only 1.3–2.3%. A \$5M food brand does about 5,960 orders and needs 172–315 extra — 2.9–5.3%. That is harder to hit, which is why food brands need higher revenue before we take them on, and why we always use holdout tests to prove the numbers in low-margin product types.

8.5 The levers that move the model

What changes	The change	Effect on a beauty brand
More customers come back	Repeat rate goes from 25% to 30%	About 20% more repeat orders
Bigger repeat orders	Average order value rises 10% through bundles	Profit per repeat order goes from \$38.93 to about \$43.85
Faster reorders	Reminder email sent at day 38 instead of day 45 for a 40-day product	Catches buyers before they switch to a competitor

What changes	The change	Effect on a beauty brand
Unnecessary discounts	20% off every repeat order	Profit per order falls from \$38.93 to \$25.27 — a 35% drop

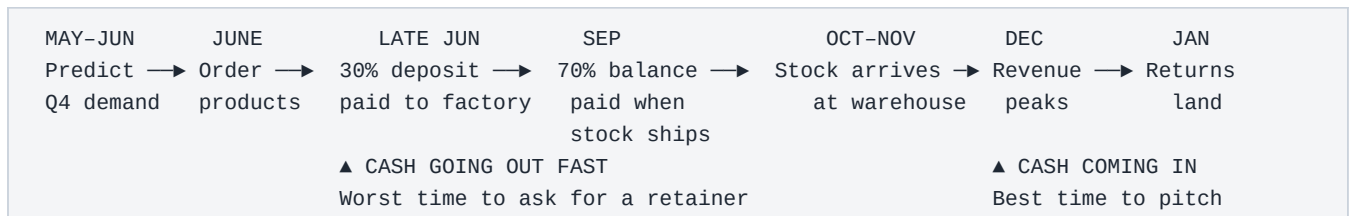
Many brands automatically put a 15–20% discount code in every email out of habit. On a \$68 beauty order, 20% off takes away \$13.66 of revenue while the product cost and shipping stay the same. Saving discounts for win-back campaigns, first-order conversion, and Black Friday — and using education and reviews everywhere else — can add more profit than building any new email sequence.

In sales conversations: Rebuild this model live on every discovery call using the prospect's real numbers. When their own spreadsheet shows that Lhotse only needs 1–3% of their monthly orders to be incremental, the "too expensive" objection usually goes away.

9. When to Sell (the Business Calendar)

Bottom line: Brands pay for their holiday-season stock in summer — so they are most cash-strapped in August and September, and have the most cash available in January and February. This cycle, more than any marketing calendar, decides when a founder will sign a retainer contract. Sell Lhotse when budgets reset and cash returns. Sell Ascent's quick, low-risk fixes when pressure is high. Never pitch a new retainer in the weeks before Black Friday.

9.1 The inventory money cycle



This cash timing gives Ascent a useful argument in the fall: *every order lost to the spam folder is inventory you have already paid for and cannot afford to lose now.*

9.2 Month-by-month guide

Month	Cash and inventory	What brands are focused on	Pitch window	What GrowMailers does
January	Returns arriving; new budgets just opened	Reviewing what peak taught them; resolutions (supplements surge)	★★★★★	Best window. Pitch Lhotse using their peak data. Pitch Ascent to brands that had December problems.
February	Recovering financially	Valentine's Day; Mothering Sunday prep (UK/Ireland)	★★★★★	Lhotse starts
March	Stable	Mothering Sunday (7 Mar); Easter preparation	★★★★	Lhotse for US, Canada, non-gifting brands; Ascent everywhere
April	Stable; UK tax year starts	Building toward Mother's Day	★★★★	Both services; Australian brands start planning EOFY
May	Forecasting Q4 inventory needs	Mother's Day (9 May); Australian EOFY prep	★★★	Australian brands must be ready by early May
June	Putting down Q4 deposits	Father's Day; Australian EOFY sales	★★★★	Second window: pitch Black Friday readiness

Month	Cash and inventory	What brands are focused on	Pitch window	What GrowMailers does
July	Getting tighter; stock in transit	Amazon Prime Day; back-to-school	★★★★	Lhotse starts still have time to be peak-ready; Ascent domain projects
August	Tight; stock on ships	Black Friday planning and audits start	★★★	Ascent first; last chance for Lhotse to be fully ready for peak
September	Worst cash moment	Final creative and list preparation for peak	★★	Last call; new sending domains must start warming by mid-September
October	Stock arriving; setup locks	Amazon Prime Big Deal Days; volume ramp-up	★	Safe Ascent fixes only until about October 16
November	Change freeze	Black Friday and Cyber Monday	☆	No pitching. Book January conversations.
December	Peak revenue arriving	Shipping cut-offs; Boxing Day	☆	Book January. December struggles feed January pitches.

9.3 When budgets reset by country

The US and Canada mostly use a January–December budget year, so January is the best buying moment. Some UK and Irish brands reset budgets in April.

Australia runs a July–June financial year, giving two good selling windows: January–March and July–August after their financial year ends (EOFY = End of Financial Year). New Zealand often runs April–March.

What we observe in their emails	What it signals	What we do
Heavy discounting in August and September emails	Too much stock or a cash squeeze	Lead with Ascent or profit protection; delay the Lhotse pitch
Pre-orders or "ships in 6 weeks" messages	Cash tied up in inventory	Low-commitment, value-first approach
Product launches and new job postings	Growth mode	Lhotse, framed as scaling what already works
Fundraising announcement	New budget and pressure to grow fast	Lhotse Scale with board-ready reporting
Founder posting about tariffs or ad costs	Profit pressure is top of mind	Lead with retention economics (Sections 3 and 8)

10. How to Measure Whether Email Is Working

Bottom line: Open rates have stopped being a useful measurement, because Apple automatically opens most emails whether or not a real person reads them. Judge an email program by click rate, purchase rate, revenue per email sent, and — most importantly — holdout-tested lift (testing whether email actually caused the purchase or the customer would have bought anyway). Healthy brands earn 20–30% of their website revenue from email and texts. Below 8%, there is basically no real email program.

10.1 How much revenue email should drive

Email's share of website revenue	What it means	What GrowMailers recommends
Under 8%	No real program	Full Lhotse build — start with automated sequences
8–20%	Underdeveloped	Lhotse: fill sequence gaps and improve targeting
20–30%	Healthy	Lhotse: optimize and test
30–40%	Top tier	Ascent to protect it; Lhotse Scale if the team is stretched

Email's share of website revenue	What it means	What GrowMailers recommends
Above 40%	Check the attribution settings	Often caused by a very wide attribution window, heavy discounting, or low ad spend

Always record what attribution window was used. Klaviyo by default credits any order placed within 5 days of an email open or click as an "email order." This overstates email's real effect, especially since Apple auto-opens inflate the open count.

10.2 Industry benchmarks by platform

Metric	Klaviyo campaigns	Klaviyo automated sequences	Omnisend campaigns	Omnisend automated
Click rate	1.69%	5.58%	0.74%	4.66%
Order rate	0.97–1.34%	1.62–2.17%	0.08%	1.49%

Klaviyo 2026 data; Omnisend 2025 data. Compare a brand only against its own platform's numbers.

Rule of thumb: On Klaviyo, if a campaign's order rate is well below 1%, the email program has a problem.

10.3 The Apple problem (why open rates are broken)

Apple's Mail Privacy Protection (MPP) automatically pre-loads emails when they arrive — this registers an "open" in the email platform even if the person never reads the email. Litmus reported that Apple accounted for 62% of all tracked opens in July 2026, with MPP affecting about 55–60% of all opens.

This causes three problems:

- 1. Engagement targeting gets wrong.** A filter for "opened in the last 90 days" now includes people who never looked at the email.
- 2. Subject line tests become unreliable.** When machines open half your emails, you cannot trust open rate as a test metric.
- 3. Inactive subscribers look active.** Your sunset policy (removing inactive people) fails because Apple keeps triggering "opens" even for dead subscribers.

The fix: define engagement by clicks, website visits, and orders — not opens. Exclude Apple auto-opens where Klaviyo allows it. Only use opens as a sign of a technical problem at one specific email provider.

▲ Most trustworthy

INCREMENTAL REVENUE lift tested against a control group (the real number)

REVENUE PER EMAIL reach × relevance × conversion

ORDER RATE did the email produce actual purchases?

CLICK RATE did a real person engage?

DELIVERY HEALTH bounces, spam complaints, inbox rate by provider

OPEN RATE diagnostic only (broken by Apple auto-opens)

▼ Least trustworthy

10.4 Targets for a healthy Lhotse client

Metric	Healthy range	When to act
Campaign click rate (Klaviyo)	1.5–2%+	Below 1% for 4 weeks in a row
Campaign order rate (Klaviyo)	About 1% or better	Well below 1%

Metric	Healthy range	When to act
Spam complaint rate	Below 0.05%	Above 0.05% (Klaviyo flags it); above 0.1% (Gmail's limit) means act now
Bounce rate	Below 1%	Above 2% (Klaviyo flags it)
Campaign frequency	2–5 per week; up to daily during Black Friday week	Only with engagement-based targeting

10.5 How to test whether email actually caused purchases (holdout tests)

A holdout test is simple: randomly hold back 10% of people from receiving a sequence, then compare how often that 10% buys versus the 90% who got the emails. The difference shows how many purchases were genuinely caused by the email.

Step-by-step:

1. Add a random split at the start of an automated sequence: 90% get the emails, 10% get nothing (use 80/20 for smaller brands)
2. Measure orders from both groups over the same time period (e.g., 14 days)
3. Run for at least 4 weeks, and until the 10% group has at least 100 orders
4. Incremental (real) orders = (rate for emailed group – rate for control group) × number who got emails
5. Report both the platform-attributed number and the real incremental number side by side

Example	Emailed (90%)	Control — no email (10%)
People in each group	18,000	2,000
14-day purchase rate	4.0% = 720 orders	2.8% = 56 orders
Real incremental orders	1.2 percentage points × 18,000 = 216 real orders	
At \$68 per order	\$14,688 real incremental revenue per month vs. \$48,960 platform-attributed	

In this example, about 30% of revenue Klaviyo "credits" to email is real. That is still a strong result. A client who hears the honest number from GrowMailers first will trust every number we report after that.

Monthly scorecard for Lhotse clients: email's share of website revenue (with attribution window noted), automated vs. campaign revenue split, revenue per email, holdout lift vs. our fees, click and order rates by segment, Gmail spam rate, bounce rate, security pass rate, net list growth, people removed, and current Klaviyo subscription tier.

11. Automated Emails vs. One-Off Campaigns

Bottom line: Automated email sequences (triggered by customer behavior) earn far more per email than one-off campaign blasts. Klaviyo's own data shows automated sequences generate about 41% of email revenue but only 5% of emails sent — at nearly 18 times the revenue per email. Campaigns still drive most email revenue overall, though. A complete email program needs both: a solid base of automated sequences, plus targeted, well-planned campaigns on top.

11.1 Automated sequences vs. campaign blasts

	Automated sequences (triggered by behavior)	Campaign blasts (sent to a group at one time)
Share of emails sent	About 2–5%	About 95%
Share of email revenue	About 30–41%	About 60–70%
Revenue per email (Omnisend data)	\$2.87	\$0.18
Share of revenue from new buyers	About 48%	About 16%
Effect on delivery	Good (goes to people who want it)	Risky if sent to everyone

Nearly half of automated sequence revenue comes from new buyers. The best brands send fewer campaigns to smaller, more engaged segments — and use the time saved to improve their automated sequences.

11.2 The customer journey and what emails go where

VISITOR → SUBSCRIBER → FIRST BUYER → REPEAT BUYER → VIP CUSTOMER

Browse, cart, and checkout abandonment	Welcome sequence	Post-purchase Review request	Reorder reminder	VIP perks Early access
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← Lost customer ← WIN-BACK ← No response → SUNSET → REMOVED from list

Cart abandonment and welcome sequences produced 76% of all automated orders on Omnisend in 2025. For a brand starting from scratch, build in this order:

1. Abandoned checkout and cart
2. Welcome sequence
3. Browse abandonment
4. Post-purchase and review request
5. Back-in-stock
6. **Reorder reminder** (most important for our four product types)
7. Win-back
8. VIP, birthday, and sunset

11.3 Specifications for each sequence

Sequence	What triggers it	Emails and timing	What they say	Discount policy
Welcome	Signs up; exits when they buy	4–5 emails: immediately, day 1–2, day 3–4, day 6–7, day 10–12	Brand story, best sellers, proof, education, founder note	First-order offer in email 1 with an expiry reminder; no stacking discounts
Abandoned checkout	Started checkout, no purchase; 7-day re-entry block	3 emails (+1 SMS if consent given): 1–4 hours, 24 hours, 48–72 hours	Cart contents, reassurance, answers to objections	Offer in last email only, for first-time buyers only
Abandoned cart	Added to cart, did not start checkout	2 emails: 2–4 hours, 24 hours	Product and reviews	None

Sequence	What triggers it	Emails and timing	What they say	Discount policy
Browse abandon ment	Viewed a product while identified; capped at 1 per 7–14 days	2 emails: 2–6 hours, 24–48 hours	Viewed item, alternatives	None
Post-purchase	Order placed or shipped; split first-time vs. returning	3–5 emails over about 30 days	Thank you, how to use it, review request at 10–21 days after delivery, cross-sell at 21–30 days	Loyalty or referral program, not discounts
Reorder reminder	Days since purchasing a used-up product; exits if reorder happens	2–3 emails starting about 7 days before they run out	"Running low?", one-click reorder, subscribe-and-save option	Subscription discount only
Back-in-stock	Customer requested an alert; stock crosses a threshold	1–2 emails (+SMS) when restocked	It's back; limited quantity	None
Win-back	No order in 1.5–2× the brand's average days between orders	3 emails over 2–3 weeks	What's new, best sellers	Staged: nothing, then soft hint, then a real offer last
VIP	Top 5–10% by total spend, or 3rd order	Welcome to VIP, then monthly perks	Early access, exclusive products	Access, not discounts
Sunset	No click, visit, or order in 120–180 days	1–2 emails over 7–10 days	"Still want to hear from us?"	Optional

In Omnisend's 2025 data: back-in-stock converted at 6.72% (\$9.14 revenue per email); welcome at 2.11% (\$6.16); abandoned cart at 1.72% (\$3.59).

Special cases: Subscription customers skip the reorder reminder and win-back flows — they get their own journey with charge reminders and options to skip or swap. Gift orders get a "treat yourself" cross-sell instead of a reorder reminder. Canadian cart abandoners can only be emailed with consent or an existing relationship (Canadian anti-spam law).

11.4 Campaign planning

Element	Standard practice
Frequency	2–5 per week normally; up to daily during Black Friday week, for engaged segments only
Segments	Engaged (clicked, visited, or ordered in 30 days); warm (31–90 days); cool (91–180 days); older goes to sunset
Who gets what	Engaged get everything; warm get 1–2 per week; cool get the strongest monthly send
Content balance	About 40% products and new arrivals, 30% education and brand story, 20% social proof, 10% offers (outside peak)
Testing	One variable at a time, measured by clicks and orders — never open rates

The best documented example of this working: Patrick Ta Beauty's Black Friday 2024. They sent nearly 6 times their usual email volume, but to properly segmented audiences. Their unsubscribe rate fell 37%, and email drove 30% of online revenue — up from 10% the year before (Klaviyo case study).

Text message (SMS) layering: Klaviyo SMS costs about \$0.009–\$0.012 per US text. Use it where speed matters: abandoned checkout, back-in-stock alerts, shipping updates, and time-limited peak offers. Keep SMS campaigns to a few per month. US marketing texts need written consent, and quiet hours must be respected.

11.5 Example: rebuilding email for a \$6M pet brand

Illustrative example, not a real brand.

Before: A single welcome email with 10% off; a checkout abandonment flow offering 15% in every single email; no reorder, browse, or win-back sequences; four full-list campaigns per week to 70,000 subscribers. Email is 11% of website revenue.

Lhotse's first 90 days:

- **Weeks 1–2:** Rebuild targeting based on clicks and orders. Move 24,000 inactive subscribers to a sunset flow.
- **Weeks 2–4:** Build a five-email welcome sequence (pet quiz, founder story, reviews, vet-backed education, then the offer) and limit the checkout discount to the last email for first-time buyers only.
- **Weeks 4–8:** Add reorder reminders for the three best-selling food products (45-day reorder cycle, first reminder at day 38, with a subscribe-and-save offer) and browse abandonment.
- **Weeks 8–12:** Add a 90-day win-back, a "gotcha day" (adoption anniversary) sequence using quiz data, and 10% holdout control groups on the welcome and reorder sequences.

How we measure it: email's share of revenue, holdout test lift vs. our fees, discount cost per order, and Klaviyo subscription tier after removing inactive subscribers.

In a food-led pet brand, we would expect the reorder reminder to become the top revenue sequence within one or two reorder cycles. Proving it with a holdout test is what turns a trial quarter into a long retainer.

12. Keeping the Email List Clean

Bottom line: Klaviyo charges based on the number of active subscribers in the list. Inactive subscribers and fake sign-ups from bots cost a brand twice: once on the Klaviyo bill, and again because sending to them hurts inbox delivery. Engagement tiers, a sunset sequence, careful removal of dead subscribers, and bot protection answer the most common complaint from brand owners: a rising Klaviyo bill with flat email revenue.

12.1 How Klaviyo charges

Since February 2025, Klaviyo charges based on every "active" profile (subscriber). It automatically bumps you to the next pricing tier when you exceed the limit. Removed (suppressed) subscribers leave the bill, but they can no longer receive any emails or enter any sequences — so removing someone is a marketing decision, not just a billing one.

Active subscribers	Monthly cost
1,000	\$30
5,000	\$100
10,000	\$150
25,000	\$400
50,000	\$700
250,000	\$2,300

Check Klaviyo's current prices before quoting any numbers to a client. A brand with 25,000–100,000 subscribers probably pays \$400–\$1,400+ per month for email alone (our estimate).

A TYPICAL UNMANAGED LIST: 60,000 ACTIVE SUBSCRIBERS (each block $\approx$ 1,500 people)

Engaged (within 30 days)		12,000	20%	← earns almost all revenue
Warm (31-90 days)		9,000	15%	
Cool (91-180 days)		6,000	10%	
Inactive (180+ days)		30,000	50%	← costs money, hurts delivery
Bots / fake addresses		3,000	5%	← costs money, causes bounces

One brand owner publicly described this exact situation: paying for 50,000+ subscribers while only about 15,000 engaged with anything, with flat revenue and a rising bill. Removing the inactive and bot segments would bring this list to about 27,000 real subscribers — cutting the email bill by roughly \$300/month — and all remaining emails would go to people who actually respond.

12.2 How to categorize subscribers

Category	Definition (based on clicks, visits, and orders — NOT opens)	How we treat them
Engaged	Clicked, visited, or ordered in last 30 days — or signed up in last 30 days	Every campaign
Warm	Same actions, 31–90 days ago	1–2 campaigns per week
Cool	Same actions, 91–180 days ago	Strongest monthly send; targeted win-back
Inactive	Nothing in 180+ days	Sunset sequence, then remove
Protected	Ordered in last 12 months, active subscriber, VIP, or has an open order or support ticket	Never remove automatically; keep in post-purchase and transactional emails

Who to remove (suppress):

- Hard bounces and spam complaints (Klaviyo does this automatically)
- People who did not re-engage after the sunset sequence
- Confirmed bots
- Disposable email addresses and malformed addresses
- People who received 3+ emails in 180 days with no click, website visit, or order

12.3 Sunset sequence process

1. **Entry trigger:** No click, visit, or order in 180 days AND no order in 12 months. Use 270 days for products with long buying cycles.
2. **Re-permission:** 1–2 emails over 7–10 days, with a one-click "yes, keep me subscribed" button.
3. **If they click:** Move them back to the warm category.
4. **If they don't:** Remove them with a reason tag (e.g., "sunset_2026Q4") so the removal can be tracked and undone if needed.
5. **Run it as an ongoing automated sequence**, not as an annual one-time purge.
6. **Report:** how many were removed, how category sizes changed, and how click and order rates changed.

One manufacturer who removed unengaged subscribers and added a sunset flow publicly reported their open rate rising from 45–55% to 65–70%. Opens are not a great metric (Section 10), but the direction confirms it: emailing fewer, more engaged people improves every other metric.

12.4 Bots and list bombing

List bombing happens when bots flood a sign-up form with real or fake email addresses. The brand then pays to store junk contacts, and their welcome emails bounce or land in spam.

Warning signs:

- Sign-up spikes at odd hours or all from one country
- Random-string names or website URLs in the name field
- High bounce rates on the very first welcome email
- Clusters of unusual email domains

How to protect sign-up forms:

- CAPTCHA or bot protection on every form
- A hidden "honeypot" field that only bots fill in (real people never see it)
- Double opt-in for high-risk sign-up sources (footer forms, countries you don't ship to, API sign-ups)
- Block common disposable email domains
- Alert when daily sign-ups are 3× the usual daily average
- Remove any subscriber cohort affected by a bot attack

This matches Klaviyo's own guidance.

Never buy an email list. Purchased lists contain spam traps and dead addresses. One documented case bounced 12% on its very first send.

13. Email Security Settings Explained Simply

Bottom line: There are three email security settings that Gmail, Yahoo, and Microsoft now require from brands sending bulk email. They all reject email from bulk senders that do not meet these rules. The three settings are: SPF (tells email providers which computers are allowed to send email for your domain), DKIM (a digital signature that proves the email is really from you), and DMARC (ties SPF and DKIM together and tells providers what to do with emails that fail). Starting with a DMARC record that just monitors — without blocking anything — meets all current requirements. Moving to blocking mode is best practice, done step by step. **A missing DMARC record — or having two of them — is the most common and most actionable finding we make in a free audit.**

13.1 How the three settings work together

WHAT THE EMAIL PROVIDER SEES	WHAT IT CHECKS
From: hello@brand.com ← visible sender	DMARC: did SPF or DKIM pass AND match this domain?
Return-Path: bounces@send.brand.com ← technical sender	SPF: is this computer allowed to send for this domain?
DKIM-Signature: d=send.brand.com	DKIM: does the digital signature match the public key in DNS?
ALIGNMENT: send.brand.com and brand.com share an organizational domain = aligned ✓	

SPF checks whether the sending computer is authorized. **DKIM** signs the email with a private key — the signature survives when the email is forwarded. **DMARC** ties both of these back to the visible "From" address and tells providers what to do if they fail — monitor, send to spam, or block entirely.

13.2 SPF — Who is allowed to send email for this domain?

An SPF record is a text record in the domain's DNS (the phone book of the internet). It lists every tool allowed to send email as that brand.

Example:

```
brand.com. IN TXT "v=spf1 include:_spf.google.com include:mail.helpdesk-vendor.example ~all"
              version Google Workspace          a helpdesk tool sending as @brand.com  soft-fail the rest
```

Rule	What goes wrong if broken
Only one SPF record per domain. Having two makes SPF completely invalid.	SPF fails for everyone
Maximum 10 DNS lookups. Each include: , a , mx , etc. counts as one lookup, including lookups inside lookups.	Permanent error, usually when an 11th tool is added
SPF checks the technical sender, not what the customer sees in "From:"	SPF can pass while the DMARC check still fails
SPF breaks when emails are forwarded	Why DKIM is more reliable
Qualifiers: ~all (soft fail, normal) vs -all (hard fail, strict) vs +all (never use — authorizes everyone)	+all means anyone in the world can send as you

Klaviyo's sending domain lives on a subdomain (like **send.brand.com**) and handles its own SPF and DKIM. Do not add Klaviyo to the main SPF record unless Klaviyo's setup screen asks for it. Shopify handles its own SPF for Shopify-sent emails.

13.3 DKIM — Proving the email is really from you

DKIM adds a digital signature to every email. The signature header says which domain signed it (**d=**) and which key to use (**s=**). The public key lives in DNS and can be checked by anyone.

Standard	Requirement
Key length	2048-bit recommended; 1024-bit minimum
Alignment	The signing domain must be the From domain or a subdomain of it
Coverage	EVERY tool that sends as @brand.com needs a DKIM signature: email service (Google/Microsoft), Klaviyo, help desk, review app, subscriptions
Rotation	Keys managed through Klaviyo rotate automatically. Self-managed keys should be rotated at least yearly, and keep the old key live for 7+ days during rotation.

13.4 DMARC — Tying it all together and setting a policy

A basic starting DMARC record at **_dmarc.brand.com**:

```
v=DMARC1; p=none; rua=mailto:dmarc-reports@brand.com; adkim=r; aspf=r
```

Setting	What it means	Starting recommendation
p=none	Monitor only — do nothing to failing emails	Start here

Setting	What it means	Starting recommendation
p=quarantine	Send failing emails to spam	Step 3
p=reject	Block failing emails entirely	Step 4
rua=	Where to send reports	Always set this
adkim=r	Relaxed matching — subdomains count	Use relaxed
t=y	Testing flag — new in 2026 standard	Use while testing quarantine

The 2026 DMARC standard removed `pct` (percentage). Do not raise a missing **pct=100** as a finding — it is not one. Bringing it up with a technical buyer tells them we are out of date.

The four-step path to full protection:

Step	DMARC record	How long	When to move on
0. Publish	p=none + reports address	Day 0	Reports are arriving
1. Discover	p=none	2–4 weeks	Every tool sending email is identified
2. Align	p=none	2–6 weeks	Every legitimate tool passes aligned SPF or DKIM; 98%+ passing for 2 weeks in a row
3. Quarantine	p=quarantine (optionally add t=y first)	2–4 weeks	No legitimate failures; no reports of missing mail
4. Block	p=reject	Ongoing	Weekly review of reports; every new tool added goes through a change request

Who sends email as @brand.com on a Shopify brand? Google Workspace or Microsoft 365, Klaviyo, Shopify notifications and Shopify Email, the help desk tool, ReCharge, the reviews app, the loyalty app, invoicing tools, HR tools, and warehouse notifications. The ones that break full blocking are always the ones nobody remembers exist.

Why Shopify brands specifically are at risk. Shopify rewrites the sender address to shopifyemail.com when a brand either has *no* DMARC record *or two of them*. This is visible from outside and is a clean, easy-to-demonstrate finding for our free audit.

13.5 What email providers now require

Requirement	Gmail	Yahoo / AOL	Microsoft
Minimum volume for bulk rules to apply	About 5,000+ emails/day to Gmail addresses. Once you hit it, it's permanent.	Bulk senders (no published number)	5,000+/day
SPF + DKIM	Required	Required	Required
DMARC	Required; monitoring-only (p=none) is enough	Required	At least monitoring-only
One-click unsubscribe button	Required for marketing emails	Required; honor within 2 days	Expected
Spam rate	Below 0.1%; never above 0.3%	Below 0.3%	Low complaints expected
Enforcement	Rejects some failing emails (since November 2025). Above 0.3% spam rate, Gmail stops helping until the rate is below 0.3% for 7 straight days.	Rejects or filters	Rejects with specific error code (since May 2025)

Every brand we target qualifies as a bulk sender. Gmail holds 54.4% of US inboxes. One campaign to about 9,200 US subscribers probably crosses Gmail's bulk threshold.

Rejected email shows up as bounces in Klaviyo — not in a test inbox screenshot. Always read the bounce reason codes.

13.6 Klaviyo's sending setup

New Klaviyo accounts start on a shared sending domain with shared reputation. Gmail shows emails as "via klaviyomail.com" — meaning the email looks like it came from a Klaviyo computer, not the brand's own domain. Klaviyo requires bulk senders to set up a branded sending domain.

Klaviyo's own warning thresholds are stricter than Gmail's:

- Spam complaint rate above 0.05% (Gmail's limit is 0.1%)
- Bounce rate above 2%

Blocks on Klaviyo's shared sending pool are Klaviyo's problem to fix. Every Ascent contract must say this clearly so there are no misunderstandings.

13.7 What is NOT a real finding

Do not use these as a reason to pitch Ascent — they are not real problems:

False finding	Why it is not a problem
"DMARC is only p=none"	Monitoring-only DMARC satisfies all three major providers
"You're missing pct=100"	That tag was removed from the DMARC standard in 2026
"No BIML is hurting delivery"	BIMI adds a logo in Gmail; it has zero effect on whether emails reach the inbox
"Promotions tab = deliverability problem"	Gmail treats the Promotions tab as part of the inbox
"One seed test shows spam, so you're blocked"	Seed test accounts have no email history — providers treat them differently

Lead with real findings instead: no DMARC record at all; two DMARC records; failed alignment; shared Klaviyo domain on a big list; Shopify sender rewrite; SPF over its lookup limit; missing one-click unsubscribe; order confirmation emails landing in spam.

13.8 Ascent repair process — no disruption to sending

Day	Work	Actions	Safety guardrail
0	Access and baseline	Read-only Klaviyo access; DNS contact info; Google Postmaster Tools setup; DMARC report inbox; record current metrics	No DNS changes yet
1–3	Inventory and quick wins	List every tool sending email; fix SPF to under 10 lookups; remove duplicate records; publish DMARC monitoring-only if missing	Add records before removing any; one change at a time
3–5	Alignment	Set up branded Klaviyo sending domain; add DKIM for Google, help desk, reviews, subscriptions; verify one-click unsubscribe	Old sending path stays live until new one is verified
5–10	List cleanup	Remove bounces, bots, and inactive profiles; build engagement tiers; launch sunset sequence; add bot protection to forms	Removals are tagged and reversible

Day	Work	Actions	Safety guardrail
10–14	Warm-up and repair	Start the warm-up schedule (Section 14); fix Microsoft-specific problems first in UK/Canada/Australia; write handover document	Automated sequences keep sending throughout
Weeks 3–12	Monitor and enforce	Weekly metrics check; move DMARC toward blocking as reports confirm it's safe; 30-day review; Lhotse proposal if the brand fits	Rollback plan for every DNS change

For large enterprise clients (A3): they usually want their own IT team to make DNS changes. For each step, give them a change request document listing the exact records to add, why each one is needed, how to verify it, and how to undo it if needed.

14. How to Test Whether Emails Actually Reach the Inbox

Bottom line: A "seed test" (sending a test email to a panel of fake test accounts) shows how an email provider treats a stranger with no history. Google Postmaster Tools shows how the provider actually treats the brand's real customers. Protect your sender reputation by only emailing people who engaged recently, measure it with real data, and only use dedicated sending IP addresses for very large, consistent senders. The industry average inbox rate is already above 80%, so using "80% inbox rate" as a success bar for Ascent is too weak. Use a full scorecard instead.

14.1 Where emails end up (industry data)

According to Validity's 2025 benchmark report, 83.5% of marketing emails reached the inbox. About 1 in 6 missed. Spam placement rose from 4.5% in Q1 to 8.6% in Q4.

Country	Gmail's inbox share	Microsoft's inbox share	Yahoo's inbox share	Overall inbox rate
United States	54.4% (88.8% inbox)	10.8% (75.8% inbox)	21.8% (86.4% inbox)	85.0%
Canada	45.5% (94.4% inbox)	27.9% (78.9% inbox)	12.2% (88.6% inbox)	86.7%
United Kingdom	41.1% (91.8% inbox)	32.3% (86.9% inbox)	7.8% (90.2% inbox)	87.8%
Australia	47.3% (92.6% inbox)	30.2% (77.7% inbox)	7.5% (86.4% inbox)	85.0%

Validity. No data for Ireland or New Zealand.

Microsoft is the weak spot outside the US. It holds about a third of inboxes in Canada, the UK, and Australia — and brands have reported months of emails going to Hotmail's spam folder even when they were only emailing 30-day-engaged subscribers. For non-US brands, check Microsoft first.

Gmail's "Promotions" tab is not spam. Klaviyo calls it "a type of inbox." No sender can choose which tab a message lands in. Since September 2025, Gmail has sorted the Promotions tab by relevance, so low-engagement senders sink within it. The honest pitch is about staying visible inside Promotions — which is an engagement argument, not a claim to "get you out of Promotions."

14.2 The measurement toolkit

Tool	What it shows	Limitations
Google Postmaster Tools	Gmail spam rate, compliance status	Needs enough daily Gmail volume to show data
Yahoo Sender Hub	Yahoo sender data and complaints	Yahoo only
Microsoft SNDS	Outlook-level data by IP address	Only useful with a dedicated sending IP

Tool	What it shows	Limitations
Klaviyo reports	Bounces, complaints, engagement by provider	Opens distorted by Apple auto-opens
DMARC aggregate reports	Every source sending as the brand's domain	Needs a report processing tool at larger volumes
Seed tests	Where a test email lands across a panel of fake accounts	No engagement history; panel mix skews the score

14.3 How to use seed tests correctly

Seed test accounts do not behave like real people — email providers treat new accounts differently. The mix of accounts in the panel also moves the score: Microsoft and Apple seed accounts place at around 75–76%, while Gmail and Yahoo seed accounts place at 86–87%.

The right way to use a seed test:

- Weight the panel to match the brand's actual mix of subscribers (how many Gmail, how many Microsoft, etc.)
- Read the results as a trend across several sends, not a one-time score
- Always pair seed test results with Google Postmaster spam rate data, bounce reasons, and DMARC data
- Real warning signs: spam placement at multiple providers at the same time, or order confirmation emails landing in spam

The Ascent Health Scorecard (replaces the simple "80% inbox rate" pass bar):

Metric	Target at 30 days	Where to check
DMARC pass rate on real emails	98%+	DMARC reports
Gmail spam rate	Below 0.1% (aim for below 0.05%)	Google Postmaster Tools
Bounce rate	Below 1%	Klaviyo
Microsoft inbox rate	Measurably better than before Ascent	Weighted seed test trend + provider engagement data
Order confirmation emails	Landing in inbox at all major providers	Seed tests and real order tests
One-click unsubscribe	Present on all marketing emails	Check email headers
Revenue per email sent	Flat or better vs. the same weeks last year	Klaviyo

14.4 Shared IP vs. dedicated sending IP

	Shared IP (Klaviyo default)	Dedicated IP
Reputation	Shared with other Klaviyo senders	The brand's alone
Volume required	None	High and consistent; gaps in sending let it go cold
Cost	Included in Klaviyo	Extra fee plus warm-up effort
Main risk	If another brand on the same pool gets blocked, you might be affected	Every mistake is purely the brand's own problem
Best for	Almost every brand we target	A3 brands with large, consistent daily sending volume

At Gmail, **domain reputation** now carries most of the weight — not which IP address you send from. For almost every brand we target, having authenticated email with an engaged list matters far more than whether you have your own IP address.

Shared sending pools do fail: one merchant reported Gmail blocking Klaviyo's shared IPs, bouncing 22.5% and 60% of two Black Friday 2025 campaigns. Even then, the fix was escalating to Klaviyo and tightening targeting — not switching to a dedicated IP.

14.5 Warm-up schedule for a new sending domain

If a brand needs a new branded sending domain (e.g., moving from "via klaviyomail.com" to sending from "send.brand.com"), they need to warm it up gradually. This is based on Klaviyo's own guidance — third-party "warm-up" services have no role here.

Weeks	Who gets campaign emails	Automated sequences
1–2	People who clicked or ordered in last 30 days	On
3–4	Engaged in last 60 days	On
5–6	Engaged in last 90 days	On
7–8	Engaged in last 120 days	On
9–10	Engaged in last 180 days	On

Only step up if spam complaints stay below 0.05% and bounces below 1%. Otherwise hold the current level for another week.

Important timing: To finish warm-up before Black Friday 2026 (November 27), warm-up had to start by about September 18, 2026. **For Black Friday 2027 (November 26), start by about September 17, 2027.** Brands that missed the window should stay on their current authenticated path through peak season and migrate in January.

14.6 How to handle delivery problems (incident runbook)

Problem	How you notice it	Severity	First 24 hours	Recovery
Gmail spam rate above 0.3%	Google Postmaster Tools	Critical	Only send campaigns to 30-day-engaged subscribers; review recent list sources	7 clean days, then ramp back up tier by tier
Bounce rate above 2%	Klaviyo	High	Read the bounce error codes; pause new sign-up sources; check forms for bots	Remove the affected cohort; re-verify sources
Microsoft rejections	Bounce reason codes	High	Check SPF, DKIM, DMARC, and alignment on that sending path	Fix, then retest
Shared IP blocked	Bounce error codes; Klaviyo notification	Medium to high	Open Klaviyo support ticket; narrow sends to engaged-only	Klaviyo moves traffic; record this in the client report
List bombing (bot sign-ups)	Sign-up spike	Medium	Add CAPTCHA and double opt-in to affected forms	Remove the affected cohort
DMARC failures after adding a new tool	DMARC aggregate reports	Medium	Add DKIM or SPF for the new tool	Add a change-request step for future tool additions
Volume jump before peak	Sending plan	Preventive	Ramp up over 4–6 weeks	Follow the peak SOP (Section 15)

14.7 Validity's "Heatwave" blocklist

On September 3, 2026, a company called Validity announced a new blocklist called Heatwave. It targets domains that use fake warm-up networks (networks of fake accounts that artificially exchange emails, opens, and replies to build a reputation). It launched with more than a million domains listed, with partners including Proofpoint, Spamhaus, SURBL, Comcast, and beehiiv.

Whether Gmail or Outlook use this list is unconfirmed. But email specialists have separately noted that filtering of cold emails has increased.

For clients: Klaviyo's own warm-up process is the right method. No one should use warm-up networks.

For GrowMails: Stop all fake warm-up activity on GrowMails' own outreach domains immediately. A deliverability agency whose own domain is on a blocklist has zero credibility.

15. The Shopping Holiday Calendar

Bottom line: Black Friday falls on November 27, 2026 in all six of our target markets — that is 60 days from the date of this document. The planning year runs from the early-October setup freeze to the following September. Market-specific shopping events like Boxing Day, Mothering Sunday, and Australia's End of Financial Year shape client calendars and GrowMails' selling windows. In 2025, US peak grew while the UK, Canada, and New Zealand were flat or down — so outside the US, peak revenue is about taking share, not riding overall growth.

15.1 Key dates: October 2026 to November 2027

Date	Event	Markets	Why it matters
Oct 6–7, 2026	Amazon Prime Big Deal Days	All except NZ	Counter with bundles and loyalty perks, not deeper discounts
Oct 12, 2026	Thanksgiving	Canada	Food and drink, gifting
Oct 31, 2026	Halloween	US, Canada, UK, Ireland	Candy; pet costumes
Nov 1, 2026	UK Black Friday campaigns begin (Black Friday week is Nov 23–30)	UK	Month-long UK peak
Nov 11, 2026	Singles Day	All	Beauty, especially in Australia and NZ
Nov 26, 2026	Thanksgiving	US	Food and drink
Nov 27, 2026	Black Friday	All six	Biggest day for all four product types
Nov 30, 2026	Cyber Monday	All six	
Dec 1, 2026	Giving Tuesday	US	Cause-linked campaigns
Dec 14, 2026	Green Monday	US	Last reliable ground shipping date
Dec 19, 2026	Super Saturday	US, UK	Last-minute gifting; digital gift cards
Dec 26, 2026	Boxing Day	Canada, UK, Ireland, Australia, NZ	Major sale day outside the US
Jan 1, 2027	New Year	All six	Resolutions: supplements, health, food
Feb 6, 2027	Lunar New Year	All	Food gifting
Feb 14, 2027	Valentine's Day	All six	Beauty, food and drink
Mar 7, 2027	Mothering Sunday	UK, Ireland	Beauty and food gifting
Mar 17, 2027	St Patrick's Day	Ireland and diaspora	Food and drink
Mar 26–29, 2027	Easter	All six	Chocolate, gifting
May 9, 2027	Mother's Day	US, Canada, Australia, NZ	Beauty's biggest non-Q4 moment
June 2027	Australian End of Financial Year sales	Australia	A month-long sale period; budgets reset July 1
Jun 20, 2027	Father's Day	US, Canada, UK, Ireland	Grooming, food and drink
July 2027	Amazon Prime Day	All except NZ	Counter-program

Date	Event	Markets	Why it matters
Late Jul–Aug 2027	Back-to-school	US, Canada	Lunchbox food, routines, supplements
Sep 5, 2027	Father's Day	Australia, NZ	
Nov 26, 2027	Black Friday 2027	All six	

One important calendar shift: Cyber Monday moves from December 1 (2025) to November 30 (2026). This means November 2026 will look stronger year-over-year and December 2026 will look weaker — purely because of the date shift. Warn clients before they try to read too much into the comparison.

15.2 How big peak season was in 2025

Market	What was measured	2025 result
United States	Cyber Week online spending	\$44.2B (+7.7%)
United States	Cyber Monday alone	\$14.25B (+7.1%)
United States	November–December total	\$257.8B (+6.8%)
Global	Shopify merchants, Black Friday weekend	\$14.6B (+27%)
United Kingdom	Black Friday week online	–1.2%
Canada	Black Friday card payment volume	–4%
Ireland	Black Friday online card spending (2024 data)	€120M (+22%)
Australia	Black Friday weekend	Parcels up 6.3%; about A\$1.5B spent
New Zealand	Black Friday non-food spending	NZ\$55.6M (–6.2%)

Why peak concentration matters for Ascent. Cyber Week (5 days) generated 17.1% of the entire US November–December season. About 1 in 6 US brands takes 30%+ of their yearly orders during Black Friday week. For those brands, a delivery failure during that one week damages their whole year. Beauty and activewear were the strongest categories in 2025 peak in the US, UK, and Australia.

Product type	Biggest moments beyond Black Friday	Email program implication
Beauty	Valentine's Day, Mothering Sunday, Mother's Day, holiday gifting, Singles Day	Gift guides, gift-with-purchase, sets
Supplements	January resolutions (the supplements "Black Friday"), September back-to-routine	Education series; subscription offers
Food and drink	Thanksgiving, holiday hampers, Easter, Lunar New Year, summer BBQ	Shipping cut-offs; gifting; perishability
Pet	Holiday gifting; flea and tick season (spring/summer); adoption anniversaries	Seasonal health sequences; "gotcha day" automations

Regional notes: The UK's Black Friday runs all month, so UK segments must be live by late October. Mothering Sunday (March 7) and Mother's Day (May 9) are two months apart, so multi-market brands need two separate campaign tracks. Boxing Day is a major sale day outside the US, and December list capacity should be held for it. Australian and New Zealand summer falls over Christmas.

15.3 Peak season email preparation checklist

12 WEEKS OUT — Security settings final; any new sending domain already warming (≈ mid-Sep)
 10 WEEKS OUT — List clean: sunset run done, bots removed, engagement tiers rebuilt
 8 WEEKS OUT — Peak calendar drafted; offers agreed with finance (minimum margin per product)
 6 WEEKS OUT — Volume ramp begins: +1 send per week to engaged and warm tiers
 4 WEEKS OUT — Segments, email creative, and sequences locked; SMS consent list verified
 2 WEEKS OUT — Quality check: links, discount codes, one-click unsubscribe, mobile layout
 PEAK WEEK — Email engaged subscribers first, then wider tiers; check spam and bounces daily
 1 WEEK AFTER — Move new buyers out of sale campaigns and into post-purchase sequences
 3 WEEKS AFTER — Remove peak-only subscribers who never engaged; plan January win-back

The rule that prevents most peak problems: Never let send volume jump suddenly. A list that has been quiet for months and then gets blasted on Black Friday will see some of that email land in spam. Brands that paused sending before peak have reported bounce spikes on their first sale email.

16. When to Pitch Which Service

Bottom line: Pitch Lhotse when budgets have just reset and there is time to build: January to February, and June to mid-September. From mid-October to year-end, only sell low-risk quick Ascent fixes and book January conversations. As of September 28, 2026, GrowMails has about three weeks of safe Ascent selling time left before the Black Friday setup freeze. The next Lhotse window opens January 4, 2027.

16.1 The master selling calendar

Window	Dates	Lead offer	What Ascent can cover	Lhotse	Message
Pre-freeze sprint	Now to Oct 16, 2026	Ascent quick fixes	DMARC on current domain; alignment; list cleaning; bot removal; spam triage	Book January starts only	"Protect peak without changing your setup"
Freeze	Oct 16–Dec 31, 2026	None	Emergency repairs only	Sign for January	"Let's review your peak data in January"
Best window	Jan 4–end of Feb 2027	Lhotse	Full, including new sending domains	Full pitch	"New budget; here's what peak revealed"
Steady window	Mar–May 2027	Both	Full	US, Canada, non-gifting brands; Australia before EOFY	"Build the system before summer"
Second-best window	Jun–mid-Sep 2027	Both	Full; new domains warming by ~Sep 17	Aim for starts by early August	"Black Friday is won in summer"

Why this rhythm matters. Klaviyo's own checklist says Black Friday is won in summer, with setup, segments, and automated sequences final by early October. Email agencies advise brands to hire email partners 8–12 weeks before Black Friday. Most teams freeze changes in November, and getting set up takes 2–3 weeks. A retainer pitched in late October is nearly impossible to deliver well and very easy to lose.

WHERE IS TODAY RELATIVE TO BLACK FRIDAY (BF)?

- └ More than 12 weeks before → Brand making \$3M–\$20M in a target product type?
 - └ YES → LFS ≥ 40? ASCENT FIRST → LHOTSE NEXT : LHOTSE FIRST
 - └ NO → ASCENT ONLY (\$1M–\$3M or \$20M+)
- └ 6–12 weeks before → ASCENT on current domain only; Lhotse proposals dated January
- └ Within 6 weeks or freeze → NO NEW PROJECTS; emergency repairs; book January calls
 - └ January–February → LHOTSE, with Ascent folded into onboarding if needed

16.2 Planning backward from Black Friday 2027

JUN 2027 Pitch and discovery	JUL Contract (latest: early Aug)	AUG Onboarding (2–3 weeks)	SEP Sequences rebuilt; new domain warming by ≈ Sep 17	OCT Setup lock (early Oct)	NOV 26 Black Friday
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For a Lhotse client to be fully ready for peak, the latest sensible contract date is early August. After that, pitch a January start instead.

16.3 How long each deal typically takes

Service and client type	Typical time from first contact to signed	Implication
Ascent, founder decides	1–2 weeks	Can close within the pre-freeze sprint
Ascent, marketing lead + VP decides	2–3 weeks	Start by late September for October delivery
Ascent, enterprise with IT involved	3–6 weeks	Best sold in January or summer. Expect a security review for DNS access.
Lhotse, founder decides	2–4 weeks	Pitch in January, start in February
Lhotse, VP or Head of Growth decides	4–8 weeks	Start in early January for March starts
Lhotse, CMO + finance reviews	6–12 weeks	Start pitching in November or December for Q1 decisions

Planning estimates. Calibrate against GrowMailers' real closed deals.

Accounts to audit per month = Target clients ÷ (reply rate × meeting rate × close rate)

With rates of 10% reply × 50% meeting × 25% close and a target of 2 clients/month:

$2 \div 0.0125 = 160$ audits per month ≈ 40 per week ≈ two researcher-days at 15–20 minutes each

Weekly rhythm:

- Monday: Build and score about 50 prospect accounts
- Tuesday–Wednesday: Run about 40 external audits and record 10–15 short videos
- Thursday: Follow-ups, discovery calls, and proposals
- Friday: Pipeline review, re-scoring, and a health check on GrowMailers' own outreach domains

16.4 Priority by market and time of year

Time of year	US	UK and Ireland	Canada	Australia and NZ
Jan–Feb	★★★★★	★★★★★ (non-gifting)	★★★★ (legal-compliant only)	★★★★
Mar–May	★★★★	★★★	★★★★	★★★ (ready for EOFY by early May)
Jun–Aug	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★★ (new budgets from July)
Sep–mid-Oct	★★ Ascent only	★★ (UK peak starts Nov 1)	★★	★★
Mid-Oct–Dec	Freeze	Freeze	Freeze	Freeze

17. Email Marketing Laws by Country

Bottom line: Cold email to businesses is easiest in the US, which runs an opt-out system (brands can email first, and recipients unsubscribe if they don't want it). It is more restricted in the UK (only companies registered with the government are fully safe), and tightly regulated in Canada and Ireland (where only specific published addresses work). Australia and New Zealand use consent-based rules with some automatic exemptions for business addresses. Cold text messages are banned everywhere. In every country: identify GrowMailers honestly, include a mailing address and a working way to unsubscribe, record where each contact came from, and never buy lists.

This section is research, not legal advice. Confirm each country's rules with a lawyer before scaling outreach there.

17.1 Rules that apply everywhere

1. **Be honest about who you are:** use a named GrowMailers sender, the real company name, and accurate email headers.
2. **Honest subject lines** that match the content. Never use "Re:" or "Fwd:" in a first message.
3. **Mailing address and a working unsubscribe** in every commercial email.
4. **Fast, permanent opt-outs**, stored on one shared list used by every tool and team member.
5. **Record where the contact came from:** the URL, the date, and a screenshot for Canada, Australia, and NZ.
6. **No bought lists, and no guessed or generated email addresses** in strict countries.
7. **No cold text messages, automated calls, AI voices, or ringless voicemail** anywhere.

17.2 United States: the basic rules

US federal law (CAN-SPAM) covers all commercial email including business-to-business, and runs on an opt-out basis — prior consent is not required. Every message still needs:

Requirement	What this means for GrowMailers outreach
Accurate email headers; honest subject line	The From, Reply-To, and routing identify GrowMailers; the subject matches the email content
Identify the message as commercial	Say clearly that the message is about GrowMailers' services
Valid physical mailing address	A street address, a registered PO box, or a registered virtual mailbox
Clear unsubscribe link, honored within 10 business days	Must work for at least 30 days after sending; no fee or login required to unsubscribe; never sell or share opted-out addresses
GrowMailers is still responsible	Even if a third-party lead-gen vendor sends on our behalf
No harvesting addresses	Scraping addresses from sites that forbid it, or generating/guessing them, is a serious violation
Penalties	More than \$50,000 per non-compliant email

US rules for calls and texts (TCPA): Calls or texts to mobile phones made with an auto-dialer or a recorded/AI voice require prior consent. Marketing texts require *written* consent. Texts count as calls under this law. The National Do Not Call Registry protects residential and cell numbers. Business landlines are generally exempt, but many founders use their cell phone as the business line — scrub mobile numbers against the registry and call manually. Only call between **8 AM and 9 PM in the recipient's local time zone**. Fines are **\$500 per violation, up to \$1,500 if intentional**. Class action lawsuits are common.

17.3 United Kingdom

- **Registered companies** (Ltd, LLP, PLC, Scottish partnerships, government bodies) can receive B2B marketing email without consent, as long as GrowMailers identifies itself and offers an easy unsubscribe.
- **Sole traders and some partnerships need consent** — check the UK companies register (Companies House) first. If no company is registered, do not cold email.
- **Named employee email addresses** (like jane@brand.co.uk) count as personal data under UK law. GrowMailers needs a written justification for why it is legitimate to contact them, must tell them where we got their address within one month (putting this in the first email's footer works), and must treat any objection as permanent.
- **A founder's personal Gmail address** almost certainly counts as an individual and needs consent (our reading).
- **Calls:** Screen against the Telephone Preference Service and Corporate TPS first. Automated calls need consent.
- **Penalties:** The maximum fine since February 5, 2026 is **£17.5 million or 4% of global revenue** — whichever is higher.

17.4 Canada — Strictest rules in our markets

Canada's anti-spam law (CASL) applies to messages **sent into Canada from anywhere in the world** — including Nepal.

- Every commercial email needs **consent** (express or implied), **sender identification**, and a **working unsubscribe**.
- **Implied consent through a published address** requires ALL three of these: the person published the address (e.g., on their company website); nothing near it says "do not send unsolicited messages"; and the message is relevant to their business role. Canadian regulators have said this is not a blanket license to email any address found online.
- **Addresses found only through enrichment tools, and personal Gmail addresses, do not qualify for implied consent.**
- **Referral exception:** one message is allowed after a referral from someone who knows both parties, and it must name the referrer in full.
- **Every email must include:** sender name, mailing address, and a phone, email, or web contact that stays valid for 60 days. Unsubscribes must be processed within **10 business days**.
- **The sender must be able to prove consent** — keep a dated screenshot of where each address was publicly published.
- **Penalties:** up to **C\$10 million per violation** for a business. Recent enforcement against Indeed Canada, Hudson's Bay, and DavidsTea all involved broken unsubscribe processes.
- **Calls:** Register with Canada's National Do Not Call List (DNCL), keep an internal do-not-call list, only call **9 AM–9:30 PM weekdays and 10 AM–6 PM weekends**, and identify yourself. The CRTC has fined foreign callers C\$175,000.
- **Quebec:** marketing must be available in French. Write in French or put Quebec lower in the outreach queue.

17.5 Ireland, Australia, and New Zealand

- **Ireland:** Email to a **registered company** is allowed unless it has objected. A **named employee email address** may count as a personal address needing consent — use generic company addresses (like

info@brand.ie) until a lawyer confirms otherwise. **Cold texts to mobiles need consent**, and many Irish founders use a mobile as their business number. Each unsolicited message is a separate offense. Ireland's Data Protection Commission closed 275 direct-marketing investigations in 2025 — up 88%.

- **Australia (Spam Act 2003):** Consent may be express or **inferred**. Inferred consent covers business addresses that are publicly displayed and where the message matches the person's business role and nothing nearby says "no unsolicited messages." Every email needs sender identification and an unsubscribe honored within **5 working days**. Repeat violations can be fined up to A\$3.3 million per day. Check Australia's Do Not Call Register before calling mobile numbers.
- **New Zealand (Unsolicited Electronic Messages Act 2007):** Consent may be express, inferred, or **deemed**. Deemed consent applies to publicly displayed business addresses — same rules as Australia's inferred consent. Unsubscribes must be honored within **5 working days**.

Our research on Australia and NZ is not complete. Treat both as frameworks to confirm with a local lawyer.

17.6 Six-country comparison and pre-send checklist

Country	Cold email to businesses	Safest address type	Cold calls	Unsubscribe deadline	Risk level
United States	Allowed (opt-out system)	Named business address	Manual dial; scrub mobiles against Do Not Call	10 business days	Low (email) / High (calls and texts)
United Kingdom	OK for registered companies; sole traders need consent	Named address at a verified company, with a written justification	Screen against TPS and CTPS first	Promptly; any objection is permanent	Medium
Canada	Only published addresses meeting all three tests, or referrals	Published role address on their website	DNCL registration; strict calling hours	10 business days	High
Ireland	Registered companies yes; named staff unclear	Generic company address	No mobiles without consent	Promptly	High
Australia	Inferred consent via publicly published address	Published role address	Check Do Not Call Register	5 working days	Medium to high
New Zealand	Deemed consent via published address	Published role address	Check before calling	5 working days	Medium to high

Before sending any email, check all of these:

- ☐ Real operating country confirmed (not just a registered-agent address)
- ☐ Address type allowed for that country's rules
- ☐ Source logged (URL, date; screenshot for Canada, Australia, and NZ). UK: Companies House match and written justification on file.
- ☐ Not on the global unsubscribe list
- ☐ Named sender; honest subject line
- ☐ Footer includes: GrowMailers full name, mailing address, statement that this is about GrowMailers' services, data source note (for UK and EU), simple one-click unsubscribe
- ☐ Sequence of 3–4 messages over about 3 weeks, stopping at any reply

17.7 GrowMailers' own outreach setup

A deliverability agency's own outreach is its first case study. Follow these rules:

- **Keep cold outreach on separate domains**, away from growmailers.com
- **Authenticate every outreach domain fully** (SPF, DKIM, and DMARC — moving toward blocking mode)
- **Stop all fake warm-up immediately** (Section 14.6 — Heatwave blocklist risk)
- **Keep volume low and human:** researched, personal emails at a steady per-mailbox pace
- Check blocklists and Google Postmaster data every week; keep bounce rate below 2%

New Shopify owners are flooded with cold sales pitches. Online communities often label them scams, and they call out Gmail senders and "your store has a problem" subject lines specifically. What works is the opposite: a specific free fix shown in a short screen recording, with no pitch attached. Public "free audit" offers in forums almost never get a reply.

17.8 Rules our Lhotse clients must follow

Rule	Which country	What it means for Lhotse
Abandoned checkout is not consent	Canada	Only email Canadian cart abandoners with consent or an existing business relationship
Soft opt-in for past customers	UK	Past customers may get marketing for similar products, with an unsubscribe in every message
Unsubscribe within 2 days / 5 working days	Yahoo / Australia and NZ	Never delay processing unsubscribes
Written consent for marketing texts	US	Separate text message consent with clear disclosure; respect quiet hours
French-language marketing	Quebec	French sequences and campaigns for Quebec subscribers
Health and supplement claims	US, UK, Australia	Review every health claim in copy against FTC, ASA, and TGA rules

18. How to Find Clients, Audit Their Setup, and Close the Sale

Bottom line: GrowMailers wins by showing real work, not just talking about it. Build a precise list of prospects. Run a 15-minute audit from the outside (no login needed). Send one specific free fix in a short personalized video. Then qualify using the prospect's own numbers. Every step in this section can be repeated by a researcher and will hold up in front of a technical buyer.

18.1 The full pipeline

SOURCE	→	GATE	→	SCORE	→	AUDIT	→	OUTREACH	→	DISCOVERY	→	PROPOSAL	→	CLOSE	→	ONBOARD
Store Leads (18.2)		Hard gates (5.1)		LFS + AUS (4.3)		15-min external (18.3)		Video + email (18.4-5)		Their numbers → model (18.6)		Ascent or Lhotse (18.8)		Signed		30-day plan + holdouts

18.2 Step 1: Build the prospect list

Store Leads filter	What to set
Platform and country	Shopify or Shopify Plus; US, UK, Canada, Australia, Ireland, or NZ
Estimated monthly sales	\$83k+/month for Ascent. For Lhotse: \$250k+/month for beauty and supplements, \$333k+/month for pet, \$417k+/month for food.
Apps to include	Klaviyo
Apps to exclude	Printful, Printify, Fourthwall; DSers, Zendrop, AutoDS, CJdropshipping
Product categories	Beauty and fitness, health, food and drink, pet (clothing as secondary)
Post-filter checks	Registered-agent address trap (Section 6.5); marketplace-led; hired email agency in last 6 months

18.3 Step 2: The 15-minute outside audit (no login needed)

Boundaries: only use publicly available DNS records and emails received as a regular subscriber. No login attempts, no scanning tools, no spoofing tests, and no contact with the brand's customers.

Run these commands in a terminal (replace "brand.com" with the real domain):

```
DOMAIN=brand.com
dig +short TXT $DOMAIN | grep -i "v=spf1"           # 1. SPF: expect exactly ONE record
dig +short TXT _dmarc.$DOMAIN                     # 2. DMARC: expect exactly ONE v=DMARC1 record
dig +short MX $DOMAIN                             # 3. What email provider they use
dig +short TXT send.$DOMAIN                       # 4. Sending subdomain (from Return-Path in their email)
dig +short TXT <selector>._domainkey.<d-domain>    # 5. DKIM key (from their email's headers)
```

Count SPF lookups manually or with a free online SPF checker (the limit is 10). Then subscribe with a Gmail and an Outlook test inbox and check:

What to check	Where to look	What a problem looks like
Sender label	Gmail "From" line	"via klaviyomail.com" or sender rewritten to shopifyemail.com
Security settings	Gmail → Show original message	SPF, DKIM, or DMARC showing "fail" instead of "pass"; From domain not matching
One-click unsubscribe	Email header: List-Unsubscribe-Post	Missing on marketing emails
Welcome email delivery	When it arrives and which folder	More than 1 hour late, or landing in Outlook junk
Sequence depth	Emails received over 14 days	Single welcome email; daily blasts to a subscriber who never clicked
Form protection	Sign-up popup on the site	No CAPTCHA; no double opt-in on risky sources
Browse and cart	Browse, then start checkout while logged in	No follow-up within 48 hours

Finding	How serious	Which service	How to describe it simply
No DMARC, or two records	High	Ascent	"Your domain has no DMARC record, which Gmail and Yahoo now require from bulk senders. It's a two-minute DNS fix."
Shared Klaviyo domain on 5,000+ subscribers	High	Ascent	"Your emails say 'via klaviyomail.com,' meaning your reputation is pooled with other senders."
Shopify sender rewrite	High	Ascent	"Shopify is replacing your sender address with shopifyemail.com because of a security gap."

Finding	How serious	Which service	How to describe it simply
Landing in Outlook junk	High (UK, Canada, Australia)	Ascent	"Your welcome email landed in Outlook junk, and about a third of UK inboxes are Microsoft."
No one-click unsubscribe / SPF over limit	Medium	Ascent	"Gmail requires a one-click unsubscribe." / "Your SPF record has too many lookups."
Only one welcome email	Medium	Lhotse	"Your welcome is one email, and there's no reorder reminder for a 30-day product."
Daily full-list blasts	Medium	Lhotse	"Sending daily to people who never click is what pushes a list into spam."

18.4 Step 3: Record a 90-second audit video

Time	What to do	Example script
0:00–0:10	Hook	"Hi [name], I'm [your name] from GrowMailers. I joined the [Brand] list last week, and your [specific email] is genuinely good."
0:10–0:35	Show the finding on screen	"One thing stood out in the headers. [Show it.] This line means [finding]. In plain terms: [impact]."
0:35–0:55	Why it matters right now	"With Black Friday on November 27 [or: Gmail's bulk-sender rules], this is the kind of thing that turns into bounces just as volume rises."
0:55–1:15	Give the free fix	"Here's the exact fix. [Show it.] Your developer can add it in minutes, and it's in the email below."
1:15–1:30	Soft close	"That's it, no pitch. If you want a second pair of eyes on the rest, just reply."

Record the real inbox or DNS output — never a generic slide — and keep it under two minutes.

18.5 Step 4: Email templates

Template A: Ascent, to a founder (\$1M–\$5M brand)

Subject: [Brand]'s DMARC record

Hi [first name], I joined the [Brand] list to study your welcome emails (the [detail] one is great) and noticed something in the headers: [plain-English finding]. Since last year, Gmail, Yahoo, and Microsoft have been rejecting bulk email that fails this check, so it's worth fixing before Black Friday volume picks up. It's a small fix, and I recorded 90 seconds showing exactly what to change: [video link]. No strings attached. If you'd like me to look at the rest, just reply.

[Your name], GrowMailers

GrowMailers · [mailing address] · A one-off business message about our email services. I found your address on [source]. Reply "no thanks" and I won't contact you again.

Template B: Lhotse, to a Head of Marketing or Head of Growth

Subject: reorder reminder at [Brand]

Hi [first name], I've been on the [Brand] list for two weeks. Your campaigns are sharp, but I didn't see a reorder reminder for [product], which is roughly a [N]-day product. At your size, a working reorder and post-purchase system usually needs just 1–3% of monthly orders to be incremental to pay for a full retention team — and we prove it with a holdout control group rather than platform estimates. Worth 20 minutes in January, once peak is behind you?

[Your name], GrowMailers · *[compliant footer]*

Template C: Ascent, to a CRM or Retention specialist at a large brand

Subject: DMARC enforcement at [Brand]

Hi [first name], I work with enterprise brands moving from monitoring-only DMARC to full enforcement without disrupting sending. Looking at [Brand]'s headers, there are [N] sending tools currently not passing aligned checks — the kind of thing that becomes an emergency the week of a big send. I've outlined the full inventory below and included a zero-downtime repair sequence. Happy to walk through it in 20 minutes if useful.

[Your name], GrowMailers · *[compliant footer]*

18.6 Step 5: The discovery call — build a financial model

Discovery call questions:

1. "What's your email's share of website revenue, and what attribution window does Klaviyo use?"
2. "How many total orders a month, and what's your average order value?"
3. "What percentage of buyers come back within 12 months?"
4. "What's your approximate gross margin?"
5. "What's your biggest email concern right now — delivery, revenue, or both?"

Build their model during the call:

Lhotse breakeven =
 Monthly fee (\$3,000–\$5,500)
 ÷ repeat order contribution (= order value × gross margin – shipping)
 = Number of extra orders per month Lhotse needs to generate

At USD 3,000/mo and a \$69 supplement at 70% margin and \$8 shipping:

Repeat contribution = \$69 × 0.70 – \$8 = \$40.30

Breakeven = \$3,000 ÷ \$40.30 = 74 extra orders/month

At 4,000 orders/month, that's 1.9% needing to be incremental

When their own model shows 1–3% needed, the price objection typically disappears.

18.7 Step 6: The Ascent proposal

The Ascent Statement of Work should include:

1. Audit findings (what we found in their headers and inbox)
2. Repair plan (which settings we fix, in what order, how long it takes)
3. Safety guardrails (what we never touch; rollback plans for every DNS change)
4. Delivery schedule (the 14-day repair timeline from Section 13.8, plus warm-up schedule)
5. Measurement (the Health Scorecard from Section 14.3)
6. Shared Klaviyo pool notice (blocks on Klaviyo's shared pool are Klaviyo's to fix, not ours)
7. Lhotse pathway (30-day review; credit against first month if they convert within 60 days)
8. Price: \$5,000 flat. No retainer lock-in.

18.8 Step 7: Lhotse onboarding

Week 1: Read-only Klaviyo access; review flows, campaigns, segments, and list; current metrics snapshot; discovery call to confirm goals; 90-day plan drafted.

Week 2: Segment rebuild (engaged, warm, cool, inactive using clicks and orders, excluding Apple auto-opens); list review and suppress confirmed bots and hard-bounce profiles.

Weeks 3–4: Rebuild the top priority sequence (usually abandoned checkout, welcome, or reorder — whichever is biggest gap); launch 10% holdout control group.

Weeks 5–8: Build remaining sequences; migrate campaigns to engaged-only targeting; launch sunset sequence for inactive subscribers.

Month 3 onward: Weekly reporting; incremental test results; ongoing hygiene; DMARC toward enforcement.

Appendix A. Word List

Word or acronym	Simple explanation
AOV (Average Order Value)	The average amount a customer spends per order
Ascent	GrowMailers' one-time email repair service, priced at \$5,000
Attribution window	How far back Klaviyo looks when crediting a sale to an email (e.g., "if they bought within 5 days of opening an email, we count it")
BIMI	A feature that shows a brand's logo next to their email in Gmail — has no effect on inbox delivery
Bounce	An email that could not be delivered. A "hard bounce" means the address doesn't exist. A "soft bounce" means a temporary problem.
CASL	Canada's email marketing law — the strictest in our markets
CAN-SPAM	US federal email marketing law — runs on an opt-out basis
CAC (Customer Acquisition Cost)	How much money it costs to get one new customer
CPA (Cost Per Purchase)	Ad spend divided by all purchases, including returning customers
DKIM	A digital signature added to emails proving they really came from the brand's domain
DMARC	A security record that ties SPF and DKIM together and tells providers what to do when emails fail checks
DNS	The "phone book of the internet" — a system that maps domain names to settings
DTC (Direct-to-Consumer)	A brand that sells directly to shoppers through its own website, not through a retailer
DNVB	A brand that was born online and controls its products from design to delivery
EOFY	End of Financial Year — in Australia this is June 30
ESP (Email Service Provider)	The platform that sends the emails — Klaviyo, Mailchimp, etc.
Flow / Sequence	An automated series of emails triggered by something a customer does (e.g., adding to cart, buying for the first time)
GTM (Go-to-Market)	The plan for finding, pitching, and closing clients
Hard gate	A requirement that must be met before we will pursue a prospect
Holdout test	Holding back 10% of subscribers from receiving an email and comparing their purchase rate against the 90% who got it — to prove the email actually caused purchases
ICP (Ideal Customer Profile)	A detailed description of the perfect type of client for a business
Klaviyo	The email and SMS platform our target brands use
Lhotse	GrowMailers' monthly email management retainer, priced at \$3,000–\$5,500/month

Word or acronym	Simple explanation
List bombing	When bots flood a sign-up form with fake or real email addresses
LTV (Lifetime Value)	The total amount of money a customer spends over their entire relationship with the brand
MER (Marketing Efficiency Ratio)	Total revenue divided by total marketing spend — a measure of how efficiently marketing dollars turn into sales
MPP (Apple Mail Privacy Protection)	Apple automatically "opens" emails when they arrive, inflating open rate stats
PECR	UK rules for electronic marketing
Replenishment flow	An automated email reminder sent when a customer is likely about to run out of a product
Retainer	A monthly fee paid for ongoing services
SAM (Serviceable Addressable Market)	The portion of the total market that actually fits our criteria
Seed test	Sending a test email to a panel of fake accounts to see where it lands
Shopify Plus	Shopify's enterprise tier, costing about \$2,300–\$2,500/month
SMS	Text messages — used alongside email in retention programs
SOM (Serviceable Obtainable Market)	The realistic share of the market GrowMailers can actually win
SPF	A DNS record listing which computers are allowed to send email for a domain
Sunset sequence	A final series of emails asking inactive subscribers if they still want to hear from the brand — and removing them if they don't respond
TAM (Total Addressable Market)	The full size of the market if GrowMailers could capture 100% of it
TCPA	US law governing calls and texts to mobile phones
Warm-up	The process of gradually increasing email volume when using a new sending domain, so email providers build trust with it

Appendix B. Sources

All data is from public sources current to September 2026 unless noted.

- **US Census Bureau** — quarterly US e-commerce revenue
- **Store Leads** — Shopify store counts, app data, category mixes (September 18, 2026)
- **Klaviyo** — Q2 2026 financial results; 2026 email benchmarks; sending setup documentation
- **Omnisend** — 2025 email marketing benchmarks
- **Validity** — 2025 inbox placement benchmarks (2024 data)
- **Triple Whale** — DTC median order values and ad cost per purchase (US brands, 90 days to September 21, 2026)
- **ShipBob** — 2026 e-commerce survey
- **Meta** — Q2 2026 earnings (ad pricing and impression data)
- **Glassdoor** — US Email Marketing Manager salary data
- **FIGS, Hims & Hers, Temple & Webster** — Public company financial filings
- **eMarketer** — DTC share of US e-commerce
- **Litmus** — Apple MPP open rate data (July 2026)
- **Flypost, Level CFO** — Email and SMS share of DTC website revenue benchmarks
- **Adobe** — 2025 Cyber Week spending data
- **Shopify** — Q3 2026 financial results

- **dmarcian** — DMARC enforcement rates among top retail domains
- **Eightx** — Team size data for online-first brands
- **Patrick Ta Beauty / Klaviyo** — Black Friday 2024 case study
- **Validity Heatwave** — Announcement September 3, 2026

Where we used estimates or planning assumptions, we said so in the relevant section.